

CM Rekha asks MCD to make city garbage-free

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta asked Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) office-bearers on Friday to prioritise keeping the city garbage-free and to improve sanitation, waste management, healthcare and primary education. The Chief Minister said the MCD has an important role in the city's development. She urged the agency's elected representatives to work together to improve basic civic services and make Delhi clean and healthy.

The chief minister made the remarks while meeting newly appointed chairpersons and vice-chairpersons of various MCD special and ad hoc committees at the Chief Minister's Janseva Sadan. Mayor Pravesh Wahi held the meeting. Deputy Mayor Monika Pant and Leader of the House Jaibhagwan Yadav, among other senior MCD office-bearers, attended the meeting. The chief minister said the MCD's cleanliness and waste disposal system directly affects the city's image and the residents' quality of life. "Making Delhi garbage-free should be among the MCD's key priorities," she said.

According to the Chief Minister's Office statement, she stressed the need for sustained efforts to ensure proper waste disposal, cleaner public spaces and a better environment in the



city. The chief minister called for greater attention to MCD-run primary schools, and said children should be provided with a better learning environment and quality education. She said the civic body also needed to improve primary healthcare services and ensure people had access to better local medical facilities.

"She assured the civic body office-bearers that the MCD would no longer have to face financial difficulties of any kind. She told them that available resources should be utilised better, with development and public service works given priority. The benefits of better coordination between the Centre and the Delhi Government through the double-engine Government should reach the capital's development," the statement said.

The Chief Minister called upon civic leaders to deliver better results in the field of primary education. She said providing children with

quality primary education is a fundamental requirement for strengthening Delhi's future. Continuous efforts should be made to further improve the education system in MCD schools and provide children with a good academic environment.

She also said the availability of better healthcare facilities at the local level is extremely important for the common people. The chief minister also urged the committee heads to work towards making Delhi a developed capital and to discharge their responsibilities with greater seriousness and dedication.

Chairpersons and vice-chairpersons of several MCD committees, including those dealing with education, environment management, medical and public health, community services, women welfare and child development, works, horticulture, licensing and tehbazari, assurances and property tax, attended the meeting.

Delhi's waste-to-energy plants more polluting than coal units: Study

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A new analysis has found that four major waste-to-energy incineration plants in Delhi have a cumulative Pollution Index score of 100, meaning they are more polluting than coal-fired thermal power plants and petrochemical industries. The Pollution Index (PI) for any industrial sector is a number from 0 to 100, and an increasing PI value denotes a higher degree of pollution load from the industrial sector.

The findings challenge the Central Pollution Control Board's (CPCB) 2025 reclassification of waste-to-energy (WTE) facilities from the 'red' category to the newly created 'blue' category, which grants critical regulatory exemptions, according to the analysis published by

the Centre for Financial Accountability (CFA).

Industrial sectors with a PI score of 80 and above come under the red category, and are subject to stringent monitoring, frequent inspections, and continuous emission monitoring. In January 2025, the CPCB created a new tier in its industry classification framework – the blue category, which was not assigned based on a PI score range.

Instead, it was reserved for facilities designated as 'essential environmental services' (EES) for managing waste from domestic and household activities, according to the analysis. Subsequently, WTE facilities, which were in the red category, were moved to the blue category.

"Blue category plants, in contrast to those put in red and orange categories, are required to 'self-assess' their



PI scores, introducing a structural conflict of interest into the very mechanism designed to protect the public from pollution," the analysis said.

The move was made despite CPCB's own reports showing that WTE facilities across India generate thousands of tons of hazardous waste per annum. For instance, CFA's study looked at Delhi's WTE plants in Okhla, Ghazipur, Narela-Bawana and Tehkhand using pollution

data drawn from CPCB's technical documents and regulatory submissions before the National Green Tribunal and the Supreme Court.

The analysis found that municipal waste incineration inherently generates three categories of pollution. One, toxic air pollutants (including dioxins and heavy metals); two, multiple streams of industrial wastewater (leachate, ash quenching effluent, scrubber water); three, large volumes of haz-

ardous ash requiring secured disposal.

Moreover, the analysis revealed that the cumulative PI for these WTE plants is 100 out of 100, unlike CPCB's cumulative PI score of 97.6 out of 100 for the facilities.

"By documenting the score as 97.6 instead of 100, the CPCB avoids admitting that WTE plants have reached the absolute maximum 'ceiling' of pollution potential," the study said. It added that WTE facilities are not only generating tonnes of hazardous waste but also emitting 68 per cent more greenhouse gases per unit of energy than coal plants.

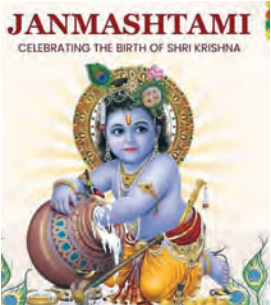
"By 'bluewashing' these facilities, the state effectively sanctions the most 'toxic industry' to continue its operation by dismantling existing environmental and health safeguards," the study said.

Delhi CM, LG extend Janmashtami greetings, wish peace and prosperity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday extended greetings to people on Janmashtami, wishing happiness, peace and prosperity for all.

In a post on X, Gupta invoked Lord Krishna and conveyed her wishes to people on the occasion of the festival marking his birth. "May the grace of Lord Shri Krishna, the Lord of Dwarka, bring happiness, peace, and prosperity to every home. May His life and the eternal



message of the Shrimad Bhagavad Gita forever keep us steadfast on the path of righteousness, duty, and the welfare of all," Gupta posted on X.

She also referred to the teachings of the Bhagavad Gita, saying Lord Krishna's

life and message should continue to guide people towards righteousness, duty and the welfare of all.

"Jai Shri Krishna," she said in her post. Sandhu also greeted people on the occasion, saying he bowed to Krishna, whom he described as the "Guru of the world".

"I bow to Krishna, the Guru of the world. On the sacred occasion of the birth festival of Lord Shri Krishna, heartfelt wishes for Janmashtami to all of you," Sandhu said in a post on X. He also wished that Lord Krishna's blessings remain with people and their families.

ABVP launches website for DUSU poll manifesto

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) on Friday launched a dedicated website to invite suggestions from Delhi University students for its manifesto ahead of the upcoming students' union elections. Students can visit 'Dusumanifesto.in' to submit their concerns, requirements and suggestions regarding the development of the university, the organisation said. The feedback will be used to prepare a student-centric manifesto for the DUSU polls, it said. The initiative comes as student organisations step

up campaigning across DU colleges, with groups reaching out to freshers and seeking suggestions on issues to be included in their manifestos.

The National Students' Union of India (NSUI) has been highlighting issues such as infrastructure, Wi-Fi facilities, regular classes and canteen food through its 'My Campus, My Manifesto' initiative, while the Left-backed All India Students' Association (AISA) has been reaching out to first-year students and raising issues related to the four-year undergraduate programme and the National Education Policy, according to members of the organisations.

VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD

Unit 203 & 204, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Navbharat Estate, Zakaria Bunder Road, Sewri (West), Mumbai 400015, Maharashtra. CIN No.: U65922MH2005PLC272501

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of Securitisation Act of 2002		
Whereas, Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd through its head office Mumbai, Notice issued to the following borrowers / guarantors / mortgagors have defaulted in the repayment of principal and payment of interest of credit facilities obtained by them from the VHFCL and said facilities have turned to be Non Performing Assets. The notices were issued to them under section 13(2) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 on their last known addresses however the same have returned un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.		
Name of Borrower, Co-borrower and Loan A/c No.	Date and Amount of Demand Notice Under Sec. 13(2)	Description of Mortgaged property
Ranjan Kumar Singh (Borrower), Baby DEVI (Co Borrower)	24-08-2026 Rs.582109/- & Rs.1408052/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Plot area measuring 37.65 sq.mtrs (45 sq.yds), Kharsa no 44/21, situated in Gali no. 1, in the area of Village Salempur Mazra abadi known as Pashuram Enclave,Pradhan Enclave,Burari , Delhi, 110084. North: Other's Property, South: Road 15ft, East:Other's Property, West: Road 20ft
LP0000000167933 LP0000000122817		
TEJO (Borrower), HARIMOHAN (Co Borrower), SHIV SINGH (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.608619/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Part Of Kharsa No. 746/2, Mauja Paigaon, Tehsil Chhata District, Mathura, Mathura, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, 281401 measuring 183.20 Sq Ft bounded by: North: House of Lokman 29 Feet, South: Road 20 feet wide, East: 68 Feet House of Lokman, West: 68 Feet House of Gajendra
MLP000000156625		
JAMNA DEVI (Borrower), RAJENDRA PRASHAD (Co Borrower), GIRISH SHARMA (Co Borrower), JAI PRAKASH (Co Borrower), RAJKUMARI (Co Borrower), Bhagwan Singh (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.978777/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, PROPERTY PLOT LAND MEASURING AREA 104.5 S.MTS. SITUATED AT IN KH.NO. 255 NAGLA BIHARI MAUZA-BHOLAIMOHAMMADPUR TEHSIL UTTAR PRADESH AND DISTT AGRA, measuring 75 square yards, i.e. 62.70 square meters, with dimensions of 30 feet from east to west and 22.5 feet from north to south, Uttar Pradesh, 282006. North: Plot of Jamuna Devi, South: Land of Lalun, East: Rasta 15 ft, West: Plot of Radhey
MHL000000162218		
Dinash . (Borrower), Neetu . (Co Borrower), Man Singh (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.974995/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, All that piece and parcel of one residential house situated at Mauja Hasla, Tehsil Kirawali, District Agra, being a single-storeyed residential house, having the following dimensions: East-21 feet, West-27 feet, North-33 feet and South-30 feet, measuring a total area of 759 sq. ft. (70.51 sq. metres). The entire area is constructed and comprises two, one kitchen, latrine, bathroom and one verandah.Agra-283122. North: House of Jagannath, South: House of Pratlap and Premshankar, East: 5feet wide road and passage, West: House of Rohitash
MLP000000213317		
SONVATI . (Borrower), KUMARPAL . (Co Borrower), ROHTASH . (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.47843/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, AREA MEASURING East-30 Feet, West-30 Feet, North-50 Feet, South-50 Feet, Total Area 166.66 SQ. YARDS, I.E. 139.35 SQ. MTRS., SITUATED AT Kharsa no. 358 Mauja Majhi bangar Tehsil Chhata District Mathura Uttar Pradesh 281401. North: Plot of Kalko, South: Plot of Harver, East: Plot of Prakash, West: Road 6mtr below
MLP000000215859		
DEVENDRA SINGH (Borrower), TARAVATI SINGH (Co Borrower), RAJVEER SINGH (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.1079047/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Property House Measuring Area 167.22 Sq.Mts. Situated at Mohli,Ramial, Ward No.3, Abhuapaura Kasba Kirawali Tehsil Kirawali, District Agra, Uttarpradesh. North: House of Siyaram, South: House of Bhagwan Singh, East: Rasta 10ft wide, West: House of Khem Singh
MLP000000294113		
DIGAMBAR SINGH (Borrower), SARJEET (Co Borrower), MEENA (Co Borrower), CHHAGANLAL (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.722298/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Residential house of land area measuring 337.50 Sq Meters, part of Kharsa No.407, Situated at Mauza Shahzadpur bangar, Tehsil Chhata District Mathura, Uttarpradesh. North: Vacant Plot of another person after 80 Feet, South: House of Bhagwan singh after 82 Feet, East: Road (less than 6 meters wide after 45.6 feet, West: Vacant Plot of another person after 44feet
MLP000000270748		
UMESH KUMAR (Borrower), SEEMA DEVI (Co Borrower)	26-08-2026 Rs.452363/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Residential Plot of land area measuring 64 Sq Yards I.E 53.51 Sq Meters, out of kharsa No.27/1, Situated at mauja lohawan, tehsil mahawan, and district Mathura, uttarpradesh, North: Other Land, South: Seller's Land, East: Land Daryav singh, West: Rasta 15 Feet
LP0000000149511		
SANJU YADAV (Borrower), RAJ KUMARI (Co Borrower)	26-08-2026 Rs.87067/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	PROPERTY AT, PROPERTY/PART OF PLOT BEARING NO. 33/77-C, AREA MEASURING 100 SQ. YARDS I.E., 83.61 SQ. METERS, KHARSA NO. 1480, 1488 1502 MIN. VAKA KAILASH NAGAR, HARI PARWAT WARD, TEHSIL DISTRICT AGRA, U.P.: 282001. North: Rasta 10 feet wide & Nikas Plot Hazra Jari Hali, South: Baldry Dharmshala, East: Plot Kusum & Savita Gupta, West: Bakliya Jagah Vikrela
LP0000000080812		
PRAVENDRA SINGH (Borrower), DHARMENDRA SINGH (Co Borrower), MAHADEVI (Co Borrower)	26-08-2026 Rs.74455/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, PROPERTY DESCRIPTION:- RESIDENTIAL HOUSE OF LAND AREA MEASURING 92.95 SQ. METERS, SITUATE AT MAUZA SALAIMABAD, TEHSIL KIRAWALI DISTRICT AGRA UTTAR PRADESH, North: House of Mukesh, South: Rasta 10 Feet Wide, East: House of Jagvir, West: Rasta 8 Feet Wid
LP0000000192837		
Saudan Singh (Borrower), Hemlata . (Co Borrower), BHURA (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.73942/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, All that piece and parcel of residential house constructed on Plot No. 39, situated at Mouza Piplya Sadipur, Tehsil and District Mathura, on land comprised in Kharsa No. 306. The plot measures 37 feet 6 inches East-West and 51 feet North-South, having a total area of 2124.44 sq. yards (177.62 sq. metres). The property comprises three rooms, one verandah, kitchen and washroom, with a total construction area of 115.38 sq. metres. North: House of Rajveer, South: 12-feet-wide road, East: House of Orni, West: House of Kailash and 6-feet-wide road
MLP000000218956		
NARESH SINGH (Borrower), KANCHAN DEVI (Co Borrower), Jitendra . (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.602644/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Measuring area 139.35 sqm, Kharsa no. 358 Mauza Majhi Bangar Tehsil Chhata Dist, Mathura UTTAR PRADESH 281401. North: Plot of Rajan, South: Plot of Dharm, East: Plot of Dharm, West: Road 6 mtr to below
MLP000000235806		
Shivam . (Borrower), SHWETA . (Co Borrower), VIKASH YADAV (Guarantor)	26-08-2026 Rs.263486/- as on 17-08-2026 with further interest and charges thereon	Property At, Property Plot No. E-6, measuring 37.851 sq. mts., situated at Gata No. 95M, Mauza-Kakrau, Tehsil and District Firozabad, Uttar Pradesh-283203. North: 11 ft — Plot of Smt. Pooja, South: 11 ft — 15 ft wide road, East: 37 ft — Remaining Arazi of Seller, West: 37 ft. — Remaining Arazi of Seller
MHL000000235123		

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (where ever applicable) are advised to make the payments of outstanding within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 90 days of the date of this notice as per the provision of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Please be informed that the said notice is also under section 13(13) informing the borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors that the said mortgaged property should not be sold/leased/transferred.

Date : 05.09.2026
Place : Burari, Mathura, Firozabad, Agra,

Authorized Officer,
VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD

RADICO KHAITAN FINANCE LIMITED

CIN NO. L74899DL1984PLC010902
4A, 4th FLOOR, MASOODPUR DAIRY FARMS, NEW DELHI – 110070
TELEPHONE NO. 011-71859609
EMAIL: admin@radioindia.com, website: radioindia.com

- Notice for 40th Annual General Meeting , Book Closure and E-voting**
- (A) Annual General Meeting:**
Notice is hereby given that the 40th Annual General Meeting of RADICO KHAITAN FINANCE LTD will be held on Wednesday, 30th Day of September, 2026 at 2.30 P.M. at Pt. Gyani Ram Farm House C/o Bijender Sharma, Advc. Near Canara Bank, Main Road Asola, Fathepur Beri, New Delhi-110074.
- (B) Book Closure:**
Notice is further given pursuant to section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 10 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, and clause 16 of the Listing Agreement, the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from 24th Day of September, 2026 to 30th Day of September, 2026, both days inclusive.
- (C) E-Voting:**
In compliance with the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended, the Members are provided with the facility of e-voting on all resolutions set forth in the Notice.

The e-voting period commences on Sunday, September 27, 2026 from 9.00 a.m. and ends on Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 5.00 p.m. The result of the e-voting shall be announced after the AGM of the Company on 01.10.2026
Notice is already available on www.mseil.in and www.radioindia.com

For Radico Khaitan Finance Limited
Krishnan Kumar Sharma
Director
DIN: 00856406

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India

1911 में आपके लिए "केन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: 4/7, DESH BANDHU GUPTA ROAD, PAHARGANJ, NEW DELHI-110055

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)

(Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Paharganj Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) and 13(12) read with the Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 22.05.2026, calling upon the Borrower(s): SMT. ANITA W/O SH. RAKESH AND SH. SONU S/O SH. RAKESH, Guarantors: SH. RAKESH S/O SH. LAL CHAND, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.24,05,453.33 (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Five Thousand Four Hundred Fifty Three and Paise Thirty Three Only) plus interest and other charges from 21.05.2026 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower(s)/ guarantor having failed to repay the entire dues of the bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower(s)/guarantor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken Symbolic Possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this 02nd Day of September 2026.

The borrower(s) and the guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Paharganj Branch New Delhi for Rs.24,05,453.33 (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Five Thousand Four Hundred Fifty Three and Paise Thirty Three Only) plus interest and other charges from 21.05.2026.

The borrower/s/guarantor's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

(Detailed Description of Mortgaged Property):

Equitable mortgage of Built-up Third Floor with Roof/Terrace Rights (Left Side from front view), area measuring 62.5 Sq.Yds. of Eastern Side Portion of Freehold Property Bearing No.J-220/23A Part of Mustafi No.23 Killa No.21 (Kharsa No.23/21), duly fitted with Water, Electricity and Sewage Connections in running / working conditions, with common rights to use entrance / gate, stair case, submersible pump, passage along with one Two-Wheeler Parking Space in still floor at Ground Level and all other common facilities situated in the area of Village Khayala and the colony known as Vishnu Garden, New Delhi-110018 with proportionate Freehold rights under the said property in the name of Sh. Rakesh S/o Sh. Lal Chand and Smt. Anita W/o Sh. Rakesh vide Sale Deed document No.4536 dated 22.04.2022 in Book No.1, Volume No.26317, on Page No.66 to 77 at Sub Registrar-II, Basai Darapur, Delhi.

Bounded as under:

North: Gali
East: Property No.J-220/22
DATE: 02/09/2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

South: Other Property
West: Property No.J-220/24
(Authorised Officer),
Central Bank of India

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public at large that Mrs. Das Sonantani W/o Mr. Prakash intended to Sell and Will dated 04.10.2026, executed by Mrs. Alka Sharma W/o Mr. Vipin Sharma, it is further informed that the said property is proposed to be mortgaged with Shubham Housing Development Finance Company Ltd. for obtaining financial assistance. It is also brought to the notice of the general public that the Surviving Member Certificate of Late Mrs. Rama Shankari W/o Late Mr. Bhunoy Dutt and the Original Notarized General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell and Will dated 13.06.2021, pertaining to the aforesaid property are not available with the Seller and are stated to have been lost/misplaced. Any person having any claim or objection must notify the undersigned in writing within 7 days, failing which it will be presumed there are no objections.

NCR LAW ASSOCIATES, Advocate & Consultants, A-98, Sector-09, New Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201009,
Mob. Nos. 9999721152/ 9999826427

PUBLIC NOTICE

The General Public is hereby informed that my client, Mr. Aslam Babar Ali, resident of House No. FA/42, Thoker No. 4, Abul Fazal Enclave-I, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, has stated as under; That my client has no connection or concern with Jamia Riyazul Uloom Society (Regd. 1999), situated at Machli Walan, Gali Nal Wali, Urdu Bazar, Delhi, for many years. That my client had resigned from the said Society and submitted his resignation letter at the Society's office; however, the receiving copy of the said resignation letter has been lost. That, in view of the above, my client shall not be responsible for any act, deed, liability, debt, obligation, or claim arising out of or in any way connected with the affairs of the said Society with effect from the date of this publication.

All concerned are therefore cautioned not to hold my client liable for any past, present, or future acts, liabilities, or claims related to the said Society.

Ismail & Associates
Ch No. 562, Lawyers Chamber Block, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi-17

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is publicly notified that the Residential Flat No.1203, 12th Floor, Tower-C, Amrapali Sapphire Ph-I, Plot No. GH-01, Sector-45, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P., has been allotted/ transferred in the name of Md. Suhail Ahmad Khan S/o Abdul Moiz Khan and Rana Tabassum W/o Md. Suhail Ahmad Khan R/o Flat No. J-402, Amrapali Sapphire, Sector-45, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh and Md. Suhail Ahmad Khan S/o Abdul Moiz Khan had executed a WILL on 25.06.2022 at Sub-Registrar-II, Noida in favour of Tauseef Ahmad S/o Late Mohammad Suhail Ahmad Khan R/o Flat No.402, 4th Floor, Tower-J, Amrapali Sapphire, Sector-45, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh -201301 and Md. Suhail Ahmad Khan S/o Abdul Moiz Khan has expired on 23.07.2026, so with the help of the notice it is informed the transfer of the above said Flat goes in favour Tauseef Ahmad S/o Late Mohammad Suhail Ahmad Khan. If any one has/have any objection he/she/they may submit his/her/their objection in the group housing department of Noida Authority along with sufficient proofs within 30 days of the publication of this notice

HIMALAYA FOOD INTERNATIONAL LIMITED

Regd. Office: 118, 1st Floor, 12 Gagandeep Building, Rajendra Place, New Delhi-110008
CIN: L70102DL1992PLC047399 Tel. +91 11 45108609
E-mail id: cs@himalayainternational.com | website: www.himalayafoodcompany.com

INFORMATION REAGRDRNG 35th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO-CONFERRING (VC)/ OTHER-AUDIO VISUAL MEANS (OVAM)

The 35th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the members of Himalaya Food International Limited ("the Company") will be held on Wednesday, September 30th, 2026 at 09:30 A.M. (IST), through video conferencing ("VC")/ other audio-visual means ("OVAM") in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the rules made thereunder and Securities Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") read with General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22 September, 2025, Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated: April 08, 2020, 17/2020, dated: April 13, 2020, 20/2020 dated: May 5, 2020, 02/2022 dated: May 5, 2022, 10/2022 dated: December 28, 2022, 09/2023 dated: September 25, 2023 and 09/2024 dated: September 19, 2024 issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") and circular dated May 12, 2020, May 13, 2022 and circular dated January 5, 2023, October 07, 2023 and October 03, 2024 along with the other applicable Circular (s) issued in this regard by MCA and SEBI, to transact the businesses that will be set forth in the Notice of AGM.

In compliance with the above Circulars, the Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report of the Company for the F.Y. 2025-26 comprising of the Audited Financial statements, Auditor's report, Board Report and other documents required to be attached thereto, will be sent only through electronic mode to those members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company/ Registrar and Share Transfer Agent or Depositories/Depository Participant(s). The aforesaid documents will be available on the website of the Company at www.himalayafoodcompany.com and also be available on the website of the BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com, in due course of time.

Manner of registering/ updating e-mail addresses and bank account details

(a) For the members holding shares in physical mode: Please send duly completed Form ISR-1 along with the requisite documents to the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Company i.e., M/s. BEETAL Financial & Computer Services Ltd., at 3rd Floor, BEETAL House, 99, Behind Local Shopping Centre, Madanpur Village, Madanpur, New Delhi, Delhi 110062. The Form ISR-1 is available on the website of the Company and can be accessed at <https://himalayafoodcompany.com/pages/forms-for-investors>.

(b) For the members holding shares in demat mode: Please register/ update your email addresses and/or bank account details with your Depository Participant ("DP").

Members can join and participate in the AGM through VC/OVAM facility only. The instructions for joining and the manner of participation in the AGM will be provided in the notice. Members attending the AGM through VC/OVAM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

The Company will provide remote e-voting facility to all its members (holding shares in demat/physical) to cast their votes on the resolutions set forth in the Notice of AGM. The process and manner of remote e-voting, the facility of joining AGM through VC/OVAM and e-voting at the AGM, for members holding shares in demat form or physical form and for members who have not registered their email addresses, will be provided in the Notice of AGM. The members attending the AGM through VC/OVAM, who have not cast their vote through remote e-voting, shall be allowed to vote through e-voting at the AGM.

Notice of Book Closure

Notice is hereby given that pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 10 of Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company shall remain closed from Thursday, September 24th, 2026 to Wednesday, September 30th, 2026 (both days inclusive).

The above information is being issued for the information and benefit of all the members of the Company and is in compliance with the MCA Circular(s) and the SEBI Circular.

All members may please note the following:

- Only those members whose name appears in the Register of Members/ List of Beneficial Owners as on Friday, August 28th, 2026 being the cut-off date, shall be

Heavy rain batters Delhi-NCR, floods airport; over 400 flights delayed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Heavy rain lashed Delhi-NCR on Friday, waterlogging roads, disrupting traffic and flight operations, dampening Janmashtami celebrations and catching many devotees off guard. The waterlogging was witnessed days before Delhi is set to host the 18th BRICS Leaders' Summit on September 12 and 13. The rain-related disruption comes as authorities step up preparations for the summit, with security and traffic arrangements being put in place across the capital. With senior leaders and delegations expected to attend the high-profile gathering, authorities will have to manage traffic movement and ensure key routes, including those connecting the airport and Bharat Mandapam,

remain accessible during spells of heavy rain. Visuals showed flooding at the Indira Gandhi International Airport, with passengers in rolled-up trousers pushing their luggage trolleys through the water to get to the entry gates. More than 400 flights were delayed at the Delhi airport on Friday, according to information available on flight tracking website Flightradar24.com. The national Capital on Friday recorded its first significant spell of rainfall in September. People stepping out to celebrate Janmashtami were caught unaware by the sudden spell of rain, with raincoats and umbrellas dotting the streets as many rushed for shelter to escape the heavy showers. Palam received 75.6 mm of rain between 8.30 am and 5:30 pm, the highest



(Left) Vehicles stranded at waterlogged Delhi Airport Tunnel following heavy downpour; (Right) Vehicles navigate through waterlogged roads near the IGI Airport flyover following heavy downpours in the national Capital on Friday



PTI

among the city's weather stations, followed by Safdarjung (32.6 mm), Lodhi Road (34.6 mm), Ridge (20 mm) and Ayanagar (12 mm), according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). Heavy waterlogging was reported near the Indira Gandhi International Airport, including at the Terminal 2

terminals, which was later cleared. In a post on X on Friday evening, DIAL said the airport experienced heavy rainfall this afternoon; as a result, the approach road and forecourt areas accumulated water."The accumulated water was cleared within some time," it added. Delhi International Airport

Ltd (DIAL) operates the Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGIA) in the national Capital. It has three terminals — T1, T2 and T3. International flights are operated from T3. Meanwhile, at least nine flights were diverted at the airport due to bad weather conditions. Four flights were diverted to Jaipur and

Lucknow, and one to Ahmedabad. The diversions happened between 3.30 pm and 4.30 pm, an official said. A squall accompanied by 7 mm of rainfall was reported at Delhi airport early Friday, which lasted two minutes, during which the wind speed reached 76 kmph and visibility dropped to 600 metres, the weather office said. Visuals from Mahipalpur showed children playing in waterlogged stretches, while Vasant Kunj, Mahipalpur and Mehrauli emerged as the other inundated hotspots. Several other parts of the city, including Maulana Azad Road, South Moti Bagh Metro station, Akbar Road, Kali Bari Marg, Basant Gaon and Subroto Park, were inundated following the heavy showers. The underpass connecting the airport with Vasant Kunj was completely waterlogged.

Parts of Lutyens' Delhi also witnessed waterlogging, including Connaught Place, slowing vehicular movement in the heart of the city. Heavy traffic and slow vehicular movement were reported across Delhi, with Subroto Park witnessing bumper-to-bumper traffic. Waterlogging affected traffic movement in the low-lying areas and locations vulnerable to flooding during intense spells of rain, including the Pul Prahladpur, Zakhira and Minto Bridge underpasses, as well as stretches around Utsav Park in Patparganj. Waterlogging was also reported in parts of Sadar Bazar, Kamla Nagar, ITO and Mathura Road. A tree fell near the Gitanjali red light on the road from the Malviya Nagar Metro Station towards Badarpur, blocking the carriageway and affecting vehicular movement, Delhi Traffic Police said.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah offers prayers on the occasion of Krishna Janmashtami at the Laxminarayan Temple, Birla Mandir in New Delhi



PM to join SRCC centenary celebrations on Teachers' Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will participate in centenary celebrations of Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) on 5th September at 7 PM. Prime Minister will also address the gathering on the occasion. The centenary celebrations coincide with Teachers' Day, making the occasion particularly significant. According to the Prime Minister's Office, the Prime Minister will attend the programme at 7 PM as the prestigious institution marks 100 years of its contribution to higher education in India. The occasion will therefore carry added significance as the nation pays tribute to teachers and educators for their contribution to shaping generations and strengthening the foundations of society. Modi's visit to the SRCC comes amid the BJP's ongoing outreach to the young gener-



ation. He last visited the SRCC in 2013, when he was Gujarat chief minister. From freshly filled potholes to new saplings lining internal roads, particularly near the entry where the Prime Minister is expected to enter, preparations are underway "in full mode," as students describe it. Several took to Instagram and X to post reels pointing out how long-pending maintenance work, from potholes

to overgrown patches, is being addressed days before the high-profile visit. Access to the event has been formalised through Google forms circulated among students, with entry expected to be tightly controlled. According to those on campus, the college's sports complex, where the interaction is likely to take place, has been partially restricted, limiting regular student move-

ment, till September 5. No outsiders will be allowed at the event unless they have filled out the registration form or have been issued special invitations. Shri Ram College of Commerce is one of India's premier institutions of higher education and a distinguished centre of learning in the fields of Commerce, Economics and Management, an official statement said. Established in 1926 by eminent industrialist and philanthropist Shri Ram, the college has, over the course of a century, nurtured generations of scholars, professionals, administrators, entrepreneurs, policymakers and nation-builders, it said. The prime minister had met the governing body and a delegation from the college at his residence in April this year to mark the institution's 100th anniversary. He had also released a special commemorative postage stamp on the occasion.

NDMC sets up 24x7 command centre, rolls out beautification drive ahead of BRICS Summit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the national Capital gearing up to host world leaders for the 18th BRICS Summit later this month, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has launched special sanitation, green beautification, maintenance, branding and decorative illumination are being undertaken at the Summit venue, VIP routes, major roads, markets and hotel areas where BRICS delegates will stay. The civic body is setting up a round-the-clock command centre to keep the city running smoothly during the high-profile event. According to an official order issued by NDMC Secretary Rahul Singh, an Integrated Command & Control Centre (ICCC) will operate out of Palika Kendra from September 5 to 14 while designated nodal officers will work in shifts to track complaints, monitor civic services, and respond to ground-

level issues as they crop up. India is scheduled to host the 18th international summit of BRICS nations — comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, and some additional countries — on September 12 to 13, as part of its BRICS chairmanship. The ICCC aims to streamline civic operations and ensure swift coordination between local civic bodies and key agencies, including the Delhi Police, Traffic Police and CPWD. To ensure that no civic issue goes unattended, officers from civil engineering, horticulture, public health, enforcement, transport, fire safety and other departments will oversee daytime operations. At night, a dedicated nodal officer from each department will remain stationed at the control room to handle any off-hour emergencies. All departmental heads and in-charges have been asked to be available round the clock throughout the 10 days from September 5 to 14.



To help the line departments and security agencies coordinate seamlessly, the civic body has activated dedicated 24x7 phone lines at the command centre. According to NDMC vice chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal, decorative electrical illumination is being arranged at 17 major roundabouts. These include Patel Chowk, Windsor Place, Mandi House, Shantipath-Kautilya, Shantipath-Panchsheel, Shantipath-Satya

Marg, RML, Teen Murti, Q-Point, Claridges Hotel, Samrat Hotel, Ashoka Hotel, Methi, Lok Kalyan Metro Station, Man Singh, York Place and PM Roundabout. He said that 11 major hotel premises will be illuminated decoratively ahead of the event. These include Hotel Taj Palace, ITC Maurya, Ashoka Hotel, Samrat Hotel, The Leela Hotel, Taj Mansingh, Claridges Hotel, Shangri-La Hotel, Le Meridien Hotel, The Imperial Hotel

and one other identified hotel premises. Trees along the roads surrounding these hotels will also be decorated with illumination. Ten major NDMC buildings and sites will also be illuminated decoratively. These include Palika Kendra, NDCC Phase-II, Convention Centre, Chandralok Building, Ashirwad Old Age Home, Charakha Museum, Central Park and Palika Bazaar area, AAV Mandir Marg, Lok Nayak Bhawan and Chanakya Bhawan. Work orders for all these works have already been issued and installation work has commenced. All works will be completed by 09 September 2026. Chahal said that 100% verification of streetlights along all Summit-related routes has been completed, and all faulty lights identified during the verification have been replaced. This will ensure improved illumination along major routes during the Summit. In view of BRICS Summit-2026, NDMC has

4-Day traffic curbs likely ahead of BRICS Summit; 4,800 personnel deployed



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Traffic movement in central, south and southwest Delhi is likely to be affected for four days from September 10 as the national Capital prepares to host the two-day BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13, officials said on Friday. Nearly 4,800 traffic personnel have been deployed to manage the movement of foreign delegations and other dignitaries.

restrictions are expected to remain in force from the arrival of foreign delegates on September 10 until their departure around September 14, with commuters likely to face diversions, traffic congestion and temporary road closures along several key routes, they added. An elaborate traffic management plan is in place for the movement of heads of state, foreign delegations and other dignitaries attending the summit. The arrangements are expected to affect vehicular movement on at least 22 arterial roads across central, south and southwest Delhi, according to officials aware of the plans. The high-level delegations are expected to travel through designated routes, with traffic personnel stationed at strategic points to aid their movement and manage regular traffic. One major concern for traffic authorities is the accommodation of the Egyptian delegation at a hotel in Saket, while the other nine delegations are expected to stay in central Delhi. The location of the Egyptian delegation's hotel is being seen as a potential issue because roads in and around Saket are already experiencing congestion due to ongoing infrastructure and road repair work. The movement of the Egyptian delegation's motorcade between Saket and central Delhi could put additional pressure on several already congested stretches in south Delhi, particularly during peak hours, an official stated.

39 Sub-registrars appointed via IT randomisation for transparency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move aimed at making governance in Delhi more transparent, fair, Sub-Registrars have been appointed across all 39 sub-divisions. For the first time, the Rekha Gupta Government has adopted an information technology-based randomisation process for the posting of Sub-Registrars. According to a statement issued by the chief minister's office, the process was conducted in the presence of the Additional Chief Secretary (Services). Under the process, some officers have been retained as Sub-Registrars, while others have been transferred from their existing assignments and appointed as Sub-Registrars. This time, officers were selected for appointment as Sub-Registrars from among a group of officers meeting



prescribed criteria, including better health, sufficient remaining service tenure and vigilance clearance. For the convenience of the public, the number of Sub-Registrar offices has also been increased to 39 from 22 earlier. This will enable Delhi residents to access both sub-division and Sub-Registrar services in their respective areas. To facilitate this, the Government has also notified 17 Sub-Registrar offices. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta expressed satisfac-

tion with the transparent and technology-driven process adopted for the posting of Sub-Registrars. She called upon the newly appointed Sub-Registrars to work with complete honesty and dedication to provide better and more effective services to the people of Delhi. She also said that her government's objective is to strengthen systems that make Government functioning more transparent, organised, effective and convenient for citizens.

CEO clarifies on draft rolls, says ASDD voters identified during door-to-door verification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi, has issued a clarification regarding the draft electoral rolls prepared under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), stating that the Draft Rolls were published on August 31, 2026, and that electors marked under the Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD) categories were identified during the house-to-house verification process. Responding to allegations by the AAP and the Congress that incomplete details of voters removed from the draft rolls were provided to them, the Delhi CEO clarified that electors who were not available or were found to have shifted from their registered addresses during house-to-house visits by Booth Level Officers (BLOs) were marked under the ASDD



categories. According to the office, BLOs completed the house-to-house visits after providing due information to Booth Level Agents (BLAs) and also conducted meetings with them periodically. The AAP and the Congress have alleged that the addresses of voters marked under the 'absent, shifted, dead, duplicate' (ASDD) categories, who were removed from the draft rolls published on August 31, were not provided to the parties. AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj and Delhi Congress chief

Devender Yadav had written to the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi, seeking details, including addresses and photos, of those placed under the ASDD categories. The draft electoral rolls for Delhi were published on August 31, after the completion of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, in which about 47.5 lakh electors out of the 1.45 crore voters in the national Capital were excluded. Those excluded can file their claims till September 30 through Form 6 with supporting documents. The final voter roll will be published on November 4. "We repeatedly told the Election Commission that the names, phone numbers and addresses of those whose names have been deleted should be shared with the political parties, so that they can be verified," Bharadwaj had said.

IN FOCUS



A children dressed as Lord Krishna pose in a lush paddy field as part of Krishna Janmashtami celebrations in Kochi

PTI

Congress leaders hold discussions to strengthen party ahead UP polls



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Ahead of next year's assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, the Congress intensified efforts to revamp its state unit, with new office-bearers likely to be appointed at all organisational levels later this month.

AICC General Secretary (Organisation) KC Venugopal held deliberations on Thursday and Friday with state in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam, state Congress chief Ajay Rai, Congress Legislature Party leader in UP assembly Aradhana Mishra 'Moni', and co-in-charge secretaries regarding organisational changes and the appointment of new district presidents. In a post on X, Venugopal said over the past two days, he has held detailed discussions with UP leaders regarding the selection of new district presidents.

Pilot sacked for AI flight scare

The pilots decided to continue to Delhi instead of diverting and later requested medical priority from air traffic control.

The aircraft landed safely at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport at 5:30 UTC (11:00 am IST). Airport medical teams treated 24 people - 20 passengers and four cabin crew. Twenty were discharged after treatment for minor injuries, while four people with serious injuries were admitted to hospitals.

The aircraft sustained cabin damage, including cracked ceiling panels, dislodged overhead-bin doors, broken handrails, a damaged emergency-exit handle and a lavatory commode uprooted from its original position.

The preliminary report also disclosed the results of post-flight medical testing. Both pilots underwent breathalyser examinations with satisfactory results and were subsequently tested for psychoactive substances. The co-pilot tested negative, while the pilot-in-command's initial sample was non-negative. A blood sample was sent to a pathological laboratory for confirmation, which was also reported as non-negative. The AAIB did not identify the substance detected or state that it had any operational effect on the flight. The AAIB has not established any link between the pilot-in-command's reported use of a psychoactive substance and the hydraulic failure or altitude upset. The technical and operational aspects of the incident remain under investigation. The pilot-in-command, 34, had about 5,055 hours of A320 flying experience, while the 32-year-old co-pilot had around 1,394 hours of total and A320 experience. Both had rested for nearly 22 hours before the flight. The AAIB recommended that the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) take appropriate action to prevent the abuse of psychoactive substances. The AAIB said no adverse weather was reported by the crew or air traffic control when the incident occurred. Investigators are therefore examining technical and other operational factors rather than attributing the altitude upset to turbulence. An Air India spokesperson said the airline follows a zero-tolerance policy on violations involving safety, fitness and regu-

Demand for good schools not anti-Govt: CJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Nashik

Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke has asked how a demand for good schools or improvement in their condition can be termed an anti-Government narrative, urging Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis to visit 'ashramshalas' for a "reality check".

He was speaking to the media on Thursday after meeting tribal students protesting in Nashik.

Dipke said the disparity in facilities, food and education provided to tribal students was "completely unacceptable". More than 100 tribal students from different parts of Maharashtra are participating in the protest at Eidgah ground in Nashik, with three of them on hunger strike over a host of demands, including



better food and students' safety. The protesting students also drew Dipke's attention to the poor condition of toilets at ashramshalas (Government residential schools), health issues and a lack of educational facilities. "The chief minister should visit the ashramshalas for a reality check," Dipke said.

He also criticised what he

called "the Government's policy of privatising schools and educational facilities", saying if it wanted to privatise schools, the state secretariat should also be privatised. To a question regarding Fadnavis's criticism of CJP as the "Congress Jitao Party", he said, "BJP leaders should first decide whether CJP is the 'B' team of terrorists or Congress. How can a

demand for good schools or improvement in their condition be an anti-Government narrative? "People removed the Congress from power because it did nothing. Now, you have been in power for the last 12 years. Present a balance sheet of what you have done," he said.

During the interaction, one of the protesting students fell ill due to the hunger strike and was admitted to a hospital. Dipke stopped the interaction and reached the hospital to check on him.

Vivek Gavit from Nashik, Rahul Pawara from Surgana (Nashik) and Laxmi Jadhav from Nandurbar are on an indefinite hunger strike demanding that the Government accept their demands. The protesters have claimed 592 students have died in ashram schools in the state and demanded compensation for their fam-

ilies and suspension of officials responsible. They have also sought the resignation of the tribal development minister in view of alleged suspicious deaths in ashram schools and shortcomings in student safety. Other demands include fresh food for students in tribal hostels instead of the centralised food system, an end to the alleged collection of money from students in the name of donations, and a committee involving tribal social organisations to probe alleged corruption in the Tribal Sports Academy.

The protesters have also sought insurance cover of Rs 10 lakh for every ashram school student.

During his visit to the city on September 2, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi had also met a delegation of protesting tribal students and interacted with them to understand their problems.

CM Suvendu reviews Bengal flood situation, says no need for panic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday reviewed the flood situation in several parts of the state and said there was no need to panic as water levels would recede soon.

Several areas of the Lower Damodar Valley have been inundated following heavy to extremely heavy rainfall, with water flowing above the danger mark in Khanakul, Jangipara and Udaynarayanpur, officials said.

Chairing an emergency meeting at the Water Resources Department headquarters, Adhikari took stock of the situation with senior officials of various departments and district magistrates. "Even if some water remains accumulated in the areas, there is no reason to worry. The situation



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari addresses the gathering during a Janmashtami festival event at Liluah in Howrah district, West Bengal

will improve," Adhikari said. He said people were being evacuated from vulnerable areas and arrangements were being made to shift cattle to safer locations.

Adhikari said the rise in river levels had increased pressure on dams, but the situation remained under control.

He also praised the Damodar Valley Corporation (DVC) for its handling of the situation and said it had reduced the amount of water being released.

"Despite the adverse situation, DVC has done a good job," he said.

"Extremely heavy rainfall and tremendous water pressure have not caused any dam to crack. Under the previous Trinamool Government, many dams used to crack during monsoon and attempts were made to control the situation by placing sandbags,"

Adhikari said. The Lower Damodar Valley, particularly parts of Howrah and Hooghly districts, remains vulnerable to flooding during the monsoon. Several areas have been inundated following the heavy rainfall triggered by the depression.

State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), civil defence and police personnel are engaged in rescue and relief operations in the affected areas.

Arrangements are also being made to provide food and drinking water to people in the inundated areas. The administration is closely monitoring the situation, with officials directed to ensure that residents in the affected areas do not face major difficulties as water levels are expected to come down.

Invader can destroy temple but not faith: UP CM Yogi Adityanath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Friday asserted that an invader can destroy a temple but cannot destroy faith. He said while invaders could erect structures over temples, they could never touch the Shri Ram and Shri Krishna enshrined in our hearts.

Speaking at a function held at the Reserve Police Lines in Lucknow on Janmashtami, Adityanath said, "We have been performing Govardhan Puja and circumambulation for the past 5,000 years, with devotees arriving in the hundreds of thousands."

He said this demonstrates that an "invader can destroy a temple but cannot destroy faith" and an "invader can break the idols but not values". He said, "They can

erect their own structures over temples, yet they could never even touch the Shri Ram and Shri Krishna enshrined in our hearts."

The chief minister said the Somnath temple was destroyed repeatedly, yet India rebuilt it time and again. The Shri Ram Mandir in Ayodhya was destroyed repeatedly, yet today it stands tall with its invincible flag ('ajeya pataakaa') flying high.

He said the temple of Lord Vishwanath in Kashi was destroyed repeatedly, yet Lokmata Ahilyabai Holkar, and in the modern era, Prime Minister Narendra Modi have restored it to its magnificent form. "This shows that those who attempted to wipe us out, those who tried to destroy our faith, have themselves vanished into the pages of history.

There is no one left to ask about



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath interacts with artists playing 'damru' on the occasion of Janmashtami at the Shri Krishna Janmasthan temple, in Mathura

FROM PAGE - 1

"We are immensely proud of our scientists, space engineers and researchers whose dedication and ingenuity continue to take India's space programme to greater heights," the Congress chief said. The Congress party has always remained deeply committed to scientific temper and space research, he said.

FBI's Most Wanted Fraudster arrested...

He pleaded not guilty in Tacoma and was released because officials noted his clean criminal record. A judge ordered him to surrender his passport and remain in Washington. His trial was set for June 22, 2026, but he did not appear. Investigators say he drove to Canada and then travelled to India. On May 21, 2026, a federal warrant was issued for breaking the terms of his release. But he was not able to hide in Punjab.

Jalandhar Police arrested him just hours after the FBI added him to its list of fraudsters and offered a reward of up to \$1,50,000 for information leading to his arrest and conviction. Punjab police arrested him under Indian law in a local case involving cheating and illegal immigration registered in May. Earlier, FBI Seattle said it was working with Indian authorities and that agents also contacted his family, including his son.

Bedi is still presumed innocent of the American fraud charges unless he is found guilty in a US court. Each wire fraud charge could mean up to 20 years in prison and a \$2,50,000 fine if he is convicted. The next legal steps will likely focus on custody and extradition, including whether he will be held for the local cheating and immigration case, whether Washington will request his return under the U.S.-India extradition treaty, and how quickly Indian courts will handle any challenges.

No ship clearance till census count: RGI

On Indian mercantile ships plying between India and foreign countries, he said persons onboard, including foreigners, on such ships will be enumerated only if they are at an Indian port at 00:00

hours on the reference date. The census reference date is the specific day and time to which all collected population data refers. According to a Government statement issued in June last year, "The reference date for Population Census 2027 will be 00:00 hours of the first day of March 2027".

"As in the case of ocean liners from foreign countries, this population will also be enumerated by the special enumerator of the Port Trust/Collectorate of Customs as per the reference date and time of Census," the order said.

"Customs authorities should be requested not to issue clearance for any ocean liner or mercantile ship on the reference date unless enumeration work of its crew members and boards is completed," it said.

The Census, the eighth since Independence, is being conducted in two phases: the first stage is known as 'House Listing and Housing Census', and the second stage is the 'Population Enumeration'. The population enumeration in Ladakh and snowbound non-synchronous areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand shall take place from September 1 to 30, according to a gazette notification issued earlier this month. For the rest of the country, the population enumeration will begin next year, a massive administrative undertaking that will use a digital-first framework to map demographics. Under the guidelines, vessels undergoing enumeration will receive an official Enumeration Certificate. Customs officials will require a duplicate copy of this certificate before allowing any ship to leave port.

To count them, the Government would appoint officials from local port trusts and customs collectorates as special enumerators.

The circular covers several categories of maritime vessels, including Indian naval ships, commercial cargo carriers, foreign ocean liners, passenger ships, fishing boats, and lighthouse vessels. For naval ships, special military or paramilitary officers will conduct the Census.

"Further, the naval ship population may be considered as belonging to an institutional household. Also, the naval ship population may be covered as a separate enumeration block(s) within the special charge (naval base)," it said.

The directive also covers riverboat populations. This group includes individuals who live on boats permanently and have no land residence, as well

87 roads shut; MeT says wet spell in Himachal to continue till September 10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Shimla

A total of 87 roads were closed in Himachal Pradesh following rainfall, even as the Shimla MeT Office on Friday issued a yellow alert, warning of further heavy rains in isolated areas of Kangra and Sirmour districts on Saturday.

Light to moderate rain continued in some parts of the state, officials said. Nahan in Sirmour district has received 67.3 mm of rain since Thursday evening, followed by Jogindarnagar (57 mm), Nadaun (52.6 mm) and Jattion Barrage and Bharwain (40 mm each), Dharamshala (34.4 mm), Naina Devi (34.2 mm), Kataula (26.1 mm) and Neri (20 mm). Thunderstorms and lightning lashed Kangra and Sundernagar, the weather office said and predicted a wet spell in the state till September 10.

Out of the 87 roads closed, the maximum number of roads are blocked in Mandi district (37), followed by Kullu (22), Kangra (8), Chamba (5), Sirmour and Una (4 each), Shimla (3), Solan (2), and Lahaul-Spiti and Bilaspur (1 each), according to the State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC).



them. Our 'Bharat' (India) remains alive and awakened to this day," Adityanath said. Emphasising the importance of positive competition in every sphere, he said. Those who tried to obliterate India's feelings ('bhaav bhangi-ma') have vanished from history. Bharat (India) continues its invincible journey even today." The chief minister said, "We must bear in mind that as long as we move along the path of duty with the spirit of selfless action, the nation's victorious journey will continue. This is not merely the task of a Government; 140 crore Indians must undertake this journey together."

Adityanath said Shri Krishna's message is meant for all. "Recognise your true self in the arena of action and strive to perform the highest form of duty.

as those who live on water for only part of the year but reside on boats during the entire enumeration period. It, however, excludes operators of river ferries who maintain land residences during this timeframe.

"All boats found at 'Ghats' situated on the banks of rivers and other waterways during the enumeration period will be enumerated. Enumeration of boat population should not be kept pending until the last day. The enumerator of the village or enumeration block of the town where the ghat is situated will enumerate the persons living on the boats simultaneously with the population residing in the village/urban block," it said. In case of ocean liners coming from foreign countries, crew members and boarders found at any Indian port at the reference date and time of Census 2027 will be enumerated, it said. "The enumeration of persons on board of such ocean liners will be carried out as per the reference date and time of the Census. Ocean liners which touch the port after 00:00 hours of the reference date or leave the port before 00:00 hours of the reference date will not be enumerated," it said. The order said officials of the Port Trust or the Collectorate of Customs should be appointed as special enumerators for this category of sea population.

Nationwide CBI raids nab three in digital arrest...

In Karnataka, a third victim was digitally arrested for a month and was defrauded of ₹15.45 crore.

The CBI stated that the three cases it was investigating revealed a pattern involving impersonation, prolonged coercion, and the quick layering of funds. Following the searches, the agency said it was looking into how mule accounts, dummy companies, and digital devices were used to receive and transfer the proceeds before they vanished into further layers of transfers. The authorities did not specify the identities of the victims and provided no additional information regarding the other persons still being traced. They stated that the seized devices and documents would be important in identifying the co-conspirators who managed the call centres, prepared the impersonations, and controlled the flow of money.

Ladakh’s long-pending barren land issue resolved

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Friday approved the regularisation rules of 'nautor lands', paving the way for the grant of proprietary rights over eligible barren land and resolving a long-pending issue concerning thousands of landholders in the Union territory.

Nautor land refers to barren or wasteland owned by the Government and historically allotted to individuals for cultivation or other productive purposes. More than 60,000 acres of land in Ladakh is presently recorded in revenue records as nautor holdings.

The new rules in Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (Nautor Regularisation) Rules, 2026, provide a comprehensive framework for granting proprietary rights over up to 10 acres of eligible nautor land to occupants across all seven districts of Ladakh, an official

spokesperson said. Nautor land beyond the 10-acre limit may be allotted on a leasehold basis in accordance with the rules.

"The rules introduce a one-time regularisation mechanism for nautor land occupied before October 27, 2020, the date on which the JK tenancy act, 1980 was repealed. Any possession of such land after the cut-off date will not be eligible for regularisation", he said.

The new framework also vests the authority to allot nautor land with the LAHDCs in all seven districts.

"Under Section 42 of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils Act, 1997, land within the district stands transferred to the Council, while clause (j) of Section 23 vests executive powers in the Council in relation to the allotment, use and occupation of land vested in it," the rules State.

Saxena said the rules seek to strike a balance between protecting the legitimate interests of



Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena

genuine nautor landholders and safeguarding public and Council land from encroachment and unauthorised claims.

"The nautor issue has a deep historical connection with the lives and livelihoods of the people of Ladakh. For generations, our people have worked hard to bring

barren and waste land under cultivation in one of the most challenging agricultural environments in the country," the lieutenant governor said.

"These rules provide a transparent and uniform mechanism to address this long-pending issue and give legal certainty to genuine

holders. It will also enable such land to be utilised as a financial asset, including for availing bank loans," he added.

The spokesperson said the absence of a clear and uniform legal framework had restricted effective utilisation of nautor land, particularly for holders who did not possess proprietary rights and were consequently unable to use the land as a financial asset, including for obtaining loans.

At the same time, the new framework is aimed at preventing disputes and unauthorised claims over Government and council land, he added.

Under the rules, genuinely eligible nautor holders can be granted proprietary rights up to 10 acres, with the amount payable for proprietary rights fixed at the market rate notified by the administration for the concerned revenue village, he added.

For nautor holdings beyond 10 acres, proprietary rights may be allotted on a leasehold basis, with the premium fixed at 80 per

cent of the notified market rate.

For 'Gair Mustaqil' holdings, field verification by revenue authorities will be mandatory to establish the identity of the occupant, area under occupation, nature and extent of cultivation, date of possession, and whether the occupation existed before the prescribed cut-off date, he added.

Gair Mustaqil land refers to a holding where the occupant or cultivator does not have the same permanent proprietary status as a Mustaqil (permanent) holder.

In the case of Mustaqil landholdings, the respective LAHDC will determine whether field verification is required based on ground realities.

The rules stipulate that abandoned land or land found to have been encroached upon will not qualify for allotment and will be liable to eviction, the spokesperson said.

Nautor land mutated before the October 27, 2020 cut-off date, where a change in land use has

taken place, may also be considered for regularisation, subject to formal approval of the change in land use by the competent authority. Land regularised under the rules can be mortgaged with scheduled banks, financial institutions and Government-backed lending agencies for development of the land.

In municipal areas, planning areas and areas covered by master plans, zonal plans or development authorities, the use of land will have to strictly conform to applicable planning regulations.

The rules also provide for periodic review and audit of allotments and regularisations. Any violation, misrepresentation, concealment of facts, non-utilisation, unauthorised transfer or breach of conditions may lead to cancellation or resumption of the land.

The rules will now be placed in the public domain for a two-week consultation period before their final notification, the spokesperson stated.

SIR: Over 43.81 lakh notices generated, 7.31 lakh delivered in Karnataka

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Over 43.81 lakh notices have been generated as part of the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls, of which 7.31 lakh have so far been delivered to electors, the chief electoral officer's office said on Friday.

The State has 4,46,38,124 electors on the electoral roll as of September 4, comprising 2.21 crore male, 2.24 crore female and 2,871 transgender electors, it said.

The notices have been issued to electors whose names fall under the "no mapping" and "anomalies" categories as part of the electoral roll revision exercise, officials said. According to a statement issued by the CEO's



office, a total of 43,81,143 notices are to be generated, of which 43,81,141 have been generated so far.

Of the notices generated, 7,31,770 have been delivered to electors, while 36,49,371 are pending delivery. A total of 206 hearings have been completed. Hearings commenced on September 3 and

will continue until October 12 before Electoral Registration Officers and assistant Electoral Registration Officers, it said.

At the request of registered and recognised political parties, lists of persons to whom notices have been issued under the "no mapping" and "anomalies" categories will be shared before September 6, the CEO's office said.

It also said 224 EROs and 4,262 AEROs and additional AEROs are working during the notice phase.

A second special campaign for registration of electors will be held on September 19 and 20 in accordance with the instructions of the Election Commission of India.

Shivraj slams Congress over Ram temple CEO appointment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Former chief minister and Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan has criticised the Congress over the appointment of retired Air Marshal Jitendra Mishra as the first full-time CEO of the Ram Temple Trust in Ayodhya.

In a social media post, Chouhan said the Congress had immediately started its "lie machine" after the appointment of the former Air Force officer. He alleged that the opposition party had failed to recognise Mishra's qualifications and work and had instead sought to create controversy by linking his appointment with Operation Sindoor.

Chouhan said the Congress had a tendency to see a conspiracy in every



Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan

appointment, politics in every decision and controversy in every achievement. Referring to a verse from the Ramcharitmanas, he urged the party to approach Lord Ram with a sense of positivity and devotion.

The remarks came after Congress leader Rashid Alvi questioned Mishra's appointment and asked what connection a retired Air Chief could have with the administration of the Ram Temple Trust. Alvi also

questioned whether there was any "hidden truth" behind Operation Sindoor that led to Mishra being appointed CEO.

Mishra, who retired from the Indian Air Force in April 2026, has around 39 years of military experience and has served as a fighter and test pilot. He was Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Western Air Command during Operation Sindoor in May 2025 and received the Uttam Yudh Seva Medal for his role in the operation.

The CEO post has been created for the first time as the temple's operations have expanded beyond construction to include management of devotees, security, maintenance, administration and multiple development projects.

The Trust received 5,585

applications for the post. A three-member committee shortlisted candidates, conducted interviews with around 16 applicants and prepared a panel of three names before the Trust selected Mishra.

His appointment comes amid a broader administrative restructuring following allegations of irregularities involving temple donations. The Trust has also appointed Govind Dev Giri as full-time general secretary and Mahesh Bhagchandka as treasurer, besides inducting three new trustees.

Mishra is expected to oversee administration, operations, coordination of projects and compliance, with improving transparency in donation and financial management emerging as a key priority.

Encroachments of gram panchayat lakes to invite criminal cases, says Karnataka Minister Khandre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Minister Eshwar Khandre on Friday warned that encroachments on lakes owned and maintained by gram panchayats would be removed without any leniency and criminal cases would be filed against encroachers.

He said immediate measures will be taken to clear encroachments covering 11,671 acres involving 4,828 lakes.

"Karnataka is the second state in the country with the largest extent of drought-prone land, and ensuring drinking water supply to rural areas remains a major challenge. Groundwater levels are declining continuously, and failure to protect surface water sources could lead to severe water scarcity in the



future," Khandre, who holds the Rural Development and Panchayat Raj portfolio, said.

Speaking to reporters, he said he participated in a two-day departmental summit on sustainable water organised by the Union Ministry of Jal Shakti in Delhi, where he presented the measures being taken by the Karnataka government for water conserva-

tion in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"In most parts of Karnataka, hard rock formations and laterite beneath the ground prevent rainwater from percolating, contributing to the depletion of groundwater. Excessive extraction of groundwater has also lowered the water table," the minister said.

Surface water sources will

become increasingly important for sustaining life in the coming years and lakes, tanks, reservoirs and rivers must be protected, he said, warning that failure to do so would result in water scarcity.

Noting that only about three per cent of the water on earth is freshwater suitable for drinking, making protection of water resources a collective responsibility, Khandre said he had urged the Centre, in the presence of the prime minister at the concluding session of the summit, to formulate a national programme to protect lakes, reservoirs and rivers from pollution caused by waste discharge as well as encroachment.

There are 32,504 lakes under gram panchayat jurisdiction in Karnataka, of which 11,498 had been encroached upon, he said.

4 held in Indore for buying and selling bank accounts used in cyber fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

Four persons were arrested in Indore in Madhya Pradesh for alleged involvement in buying and selling bank accounts for use in cyber fraud, a police official said on Friday.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Aman Singh Rathore identified the four as Monish Mandloi (29), Piyush Kushwah (22), Rishi Pawar (20) and Sujal Soni (20). Search is on for another associate identified as Rupesh Mangrolia (26), he added.

"During questioning, Mandloi claimed he opened a bank account at the request of Kushwah and handed over the entire bank kit, including the passbook, cheque book and ATM card, to him for ₹2,000. Kushwah then sold the account to



Pawar for ₹5,000, who further sold it for ₹10,000," Rathore said.

The investigation also revealed that money allegedly obtained from people through fraud on the pretext of converting USDT digital cryptocurrency into Indian rupees was routed through various bank accounts, the DCP said.

"One of the bank accounts linked to the gang was found connected to cyber fraud complaints registered in Andhra Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh," he said.

A case was registered under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Information Technology Act, and further probe is underway, Rathore said.

Naidu asks TDP cadre to gear up for local body polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday directed the TDP machinery to gear up for the upcoming local body elections and aim for a better strike rate than in the 2024 Assembly polls, while stressing coordination among NDA partners.

Naidu held a meeting with ministers and zonal observers to discuss the party's strategy for the local body elections, according to a press release issued late on Thursday.

He said the local body elections would provide an opportunity to assess the party's current position compared to the 2024 polls.

Janmashtami fervour grips Mumbai as devotees throng temples

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Aartis and bhajans filled the air as religious fervour swept Mumbai on Friday, with Krishna temples across the city opening to massive crowds of faithfuls gathering for early prayers on Janmashtami.

The city is also gearing up for Saturday's Dahi Handi celebrations, when several spirited teams of Govindas will build human pyramids to break curd and milk-filled earthen pots suspended at considerable heights on street corners.

Krishna Janmashtami, also known as Krishnashtami, commemorates the birth of Lord Krishna, the eighth avatar of Vishnu.

Flowers and vibrant lights adorned Lord Krishna temples across the metropolis, setting the backdrop for devotional programmes and special prayers.

At the ISKCON temple in Girgaon Chowpatty, a grand



'Mangala Aarti' started the early-morning rituals, drawing steady streams of devotees.

Extending his greetings to devotees worldwide, spiritual leader Keshav Chandra Das termed Janmashtami a deeply auspicious occasion.

"Lord Sri Krishna was born at midnight, in the darkness, and He illuminated the entire world through the Bhagavad Gita. Through Arjuna, He delivered a very beautiful and essential message to all of humanity," Das said.

The excitement was equally palpable across residential societies, where

adults and children joined in traditional cultural performances ahead of household pujas, which will begin at midnight.

Meanwhile, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation and police have put elaborate security protocols and traffic diversions in place at major venues to handle the massive turnout expected for Saturday's Dahi Handi festivities. With prominent political leaders and organisations hosting Dahi Handi events, the festivities are set to draw celebrities, massive crowds, and Govinda teams competing for trophies and cash prizes.

40 high-hazard glacial lakes identified in Sikkim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

The eastern Himalayan state of Sikkim has identified 40 high-hazard glacial lakes, with 16 of them classified as being at the highest risk of catastrophic outbursts that could threaten downstream settlements.

The data is significant as it comes against the backdrop of the recent flash flood in Nepal, triggered by a glacial collapse near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26 that left a trail of destruction with hundreds of people dead and scores missing.

Though the catastrophe was not linked to a Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF), the flash flood has highlighted a broader transformation across the Himalayas as glaciers retreat, new lakes are forming in their place, while existing ones are expanding.

Glacial lakes are formed by the melting of glaciers and accumulation of meltwater in depressions on or near the glacier's surface. GLOFs occur when these lakes suddenly burst open due to factors



such as excessive water accumulation or triggers like earthquakes.

These floods can cause significant destruction and pose serious risks to people and the environment downstream.

One such outburst in Sikkim in October 2023 resulted in at least 60 fatalities and extensive damage in the Mangan, Gangtok, Pakyong and Namchi districts. It also destroyed the Chungthang dam, a crucial part of a major hydropower project.

At a media sensitisation workshop on GLOF Risk Mitigation held here on Thursday, Principal Secretary Sandeep Tambe said remote

sensing and satellite imagery were being used to monitor changes in glacial lakes.

Of the 40 high-hazard lakes, 16 are in Category A (highest risk), two in Category B (high risk) and nine in Category C (moderate to low risk), while 13 remain unclassified, he said.

The workshop focused on strengthening public understanding of GLOF risks and ensuring that verified, science-based information reaches the public.

Yougan Tamang, the press secretary to Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang, said media sensitisation was crucial to communicating the scientific measures being

undertaken to mitigate GLOF risks.

Sikkim's Department of Science and Technology was designated the nodal department for GLOF hazard assessment and mitigation studies in February 2025, with the work being carried out through an interdisciplinary approach, Tamang said.

The state is also working towards what could be the country's first dedicated GLOF Risk Mitigation Protocol, aimed at creating a standardised scientific framework for assessing, preparing for and mitigating glacial flood risks.

It could also serve as a model for other Himalayan regions, an official release said.

Field studies cover water-level and discharge monitoring, Electrical Resistivity Tomography, geophysical and differential global positioning system surveys, bathymetry, flood modelling, hazard assessment and feasibility studies for lowering lake levels and constructing flood-retention structures.

Tambe said a uniform strat-

egy could not be applied to all lakes, and separate proposals had therefore been prepared for the Lhonak Complex, Shako Chho Lake and Gurudongmar Complex, according to the release.

The Sikkim government has identified Shako Chho as most vulnerable to GLOF.

The Detailed Project Report (DPR) for Shako Chho has been submitted to the National Disaster Management Authority, and a preliminary project report has been sent to the Jal Shakti Ministry.

The Central Water Commission is preparing a DPR along with the Sikkim government for a flood-retention structure at Dolma Sampa near Muguthang in the Lhonak Complex.

For the Gurudongmar Complex, a moraine plug wall at the lake outlet has been proposed. The Department of Science and Technology and Brahmaputra Board are jointly working on the proposal, taking into account both GLOF risk and the lake's cultural and religious significance.

■ States Focus ■



RESEARCH SHOULD SOLVE REAL PROBLEMS: VP RADHAKRISHNAN

Calling upon researchers and innovators of Panjab University, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Friday stressed that research should solve real problems and make an impact on society.

Radhakrishnan visited PU and inaugurated the upgraded advanced instrumentation facility at the Sophisticated Analytical Instrumentation Facility/Central Instrumentation Laboratory (SAIF/CIL). He also inaugurated the PU Technology Innovation Forum (PU TIF), formerly BioNEST, which provides an integrated platform for pre-incubation, incubation and post-incubation. While referring to the inauguration of the advanced instrumentation facility, the vice president asserted that any research should make an impact on society. (PTI)



END CASTE SYSTEM, WILL GIVE UP RESERVATIONS: ATHAWALE

Union Minister Ramdas Athawale on Friday asserted that reservations were a constitutional right, and said that the beneficiaries were ready to give up quotas if casteism was eradicated from society. Addressing reporters, the Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment said Scheduled Tribes, Scheduled Castes and Other Backward Castes (OBCs) together enjoy 49.5% reservations, while Economically Weaker Sections (EWS), with an annual income of less than ₹8 lakh, get a 10% quota. "If the caste system is eradicated, we are ready to give up reservations," the Republican Party of India (Athawale) president said. He said the reservations were introduced for SCs and STs when the Constitution was adopted on January 26, 1950, and later the benefits were extended to OBC and EWS categories. (PTI)

NIA links US, Ukrainian suspects to Myanmar aircraft attack

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) told a Delhi court that American citizen Matthew Aaron Van Dyke and six Ukrainian nationals arrested in March were involved in a drone attack on a civilian plane in Myanmar. The agency also claimed the group was planning terror activities in India and asked for permission to question two of the accused in Tihar jail. Special Judge Prashant Sharma at Patiala House Courts approved the request. The court said that interrogation is a normal part of an investigation and that courts should not usually interfere while an investigation is ongoing.

The NIA wanted to question Van Dyke and Ukrainian national Kaminskyi Viktor, who are both in Tihar jail. All seven men were arrested on March 13, 2026. Van Dyke was stopped at Kolkata airport, while the six Ukrainians, Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor, were detained at airports in Lucknow and Delhi. They appeared before the special



NIA court at Patiala House and were charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. They have been in Tihar Jail since early April. In its August 19 application, the NIA said the central Government had credible information that some Ukrainian and US nationals were involved in a drone attack on a civilian plane in Myanmar.

The agency connected this information to the same network it was already investigating in the March case. The NIA said that 14 Ukrainian nationals entered India on tourist visas at different times and flew to Guwahati. They then travelled to Mizoram without the special permits required for foreigners to visit the State's protected and restricted areas.

The agency said the group then entered Myanmar ille-

gally to give planned training in drone warfare, drone operations, assembly, and jamming technology to ethnic armed groups in Myanmar who are fighting the country's military Government. The NIA also said that Van Dyke and the Ukrainians they arrested contacted these groups and joined the training activities.

The agency also claimed that these groups were connected to insurgent organisations in Northeast India. The accused have been charged under Section 18 of the UAPA, which covers conspiracy to commit a terrorist act, among other charges. The agency told the court that data from devices seized from the accused included images, videos, and voice samples it called "incriminating." The NIA said this material needed to be shown to the arrested

men and checked against their statements.

The NIA said it needed to question Van Dyke and Kaminskyi to get information about other suspects, described as masterminds in Myanmar, and to confront them with facts given by witnesses. The court approved the request on August 31. Questioning inside Tihar Jail was allowed as part of the ongoing investigation.

A Ukrainian translator was assigned to help during Kaminskyi's questioning. The defence opposed further interrogation at this point, saying the request lacked sufficient legal or factual support. The court rejected this argument, saying that no law or judgment prevented it from allowing the NIA to question the accused in jail. The March arrests happened after the group allegedly travelled through Assam and Mizoram as tourists.

The NIA argues that the group's journey went beyond what is allowed for tourists and that the accused used Indian territory to reach Myanmar without the required documents for restricted border areas. Van Dyke and the six Ukrainians are still in Tihar jail while the NIA continues its probe.

BJP hits at Rahul's patriarchy remark



BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday attacked Rahul Gandhi, saying "smash the prospects of women" is the real mindset of the Congress leader and his party's Governments.

"For Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, the slogan 'smash the patriarchy' is nothing but empty words and political rhetoric," BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj told reporters.

This came a day after Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy sacked Forest Minister Konda Surekha from the Council of Ministers with immediate effect amid a row over some remarks made against him and others by the woman leader's daughter.

Surekha, on her part, claimed she did nothing wrong and accused the chief minister of doing "blackmail politics".

Reacting to the development, Swaraj said, "Just yesterday, in Telangana, we witnessed how a senior leader from his (Rahul Gandhi's) own party, the Congress, was humiliated and dropped from the Cabinet by the Congress Government in the State."

Surekha has levelled "extremely serious" allegations against the Congress Government and the Telangana chief minister, she said. "I want to ask why

Rahul Gandhi remains silent regarding these accusations of injustice and blackmail? Perhaps it is because, for him, 'smash the patriarchy' is merely an election slogan, nothing more than political rhetoric," she added.

Swaraj alleged that in reality, the mindset of Gandhi, the Congress and its Governments is to "smash the prospects of women if they are progressive".

"You may have observed that in Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka – the states governed by the Congress – not a single woman was deemed worthy of being entrusted with the responsibility of a ministerial post," the BJP leader added.

Addressing an event in Pune on August 22, Gandhi had lashed out at the "Manusmriti mindset" and urged girl students to "smash patriarchy", while also taking a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his remark that he was shocked to hear girls using abusive language during the recent protest at Jantar Mantar.

Interacting with girl students at his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' outreach programme here, Gandhi said women belong to themselves and not to their fathers, husbands or sons, and termed as shameful the Manusmriti's prescription that a woman should remain under the authority of male relatives at every stage of her life.

Tribal students' fight for identity: Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday said the fight of tribal students from Maharashtra is not just for education, employment, hostels, and food, but it is also for their existence and Adivasi identity.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha shared on X a video of his interaction with tribal students on Wednesday during his visit



to Nashik.

In a post in Hindi on X accompanying the video,

Gandhi said, "'We are Adivasis; RSS-BJP want to turn us into Vanvasis'. The fight of tribal students from Nashik and Maharashtra is not just for education, employment, hostels, and food-it's also for their existence and Adivasi identity."

It was a pleasure to meet these brave students, who stood firm against the Maharashtra Government, raised their voice for their rights, and achieved victory, Gandhi said.

"Promised the students- we, the Congress, and I stand with them in every fight for their rights," he said.

Gandhi had met the delegation of tribal students, including those who were on a hunger strike to press for their demands, during his visit to Nashik in Maharashtra on Wednesday.

The students were protesting over a range of issues, including the condition of ashram schools meant for tribals.

West Bengal Govt to set up 1,000 RSS-run schools

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Suvendu Adhikari Government wants to set up at least 1000 schools – affiliated to Vidya Bharati Akhil Bharatiya Siksha Sansthan, the educational wing of RSS – in Bengal. Besides, his Government is also likely to merge the entire education departments of the State into one, thus bringing the Madarsa education system under one umbrella, sources said.

The Bengal Chief Minister urged the Vidya Bharati to open schools in every district and municipal areas so as to impart nationalistic and patriotic culture among the students.

Asking the Sansthan to open more schools in districts like Murshidabad and South 24 Parganas, the Chief Minister said that these districts needed to develop more patriotic feeling among the students through these schools to counter the anti-national activities that had been taking place in these



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari

areas. Vidya Bharati presently runs little more than 300 schools in West Bengal.

Murshidabad district, which has about 68 per cent Muslim population, had witnessed massive communal riots last year, forcing several thousand people to flee to the neighbouring Malda district. The then Mamata Banerjee Government had come under severe criticism from the opposition for allowing the Hindu population to be attacked, with the police looking the other way.

Criticising the previous Government the Chief Minister also expressed his views about running separate edu-

cational institutions by the minorities' department thus bringing the Madarsa education under a single umbrella with the mainstream schools. Incidentally, the budgetary allocation for the Madarsa boards had already been slashed by about 40 per cent this year.

Standing by the ideology that his Government represented the Chief Minister said, "we have come to power with a particular ideology which speaks about 'one Constitution, one symbol, one leader' as professed by Shyama Prasad Mukherjee... so there should be a single system (of educa-

tion) for all the universities and higher education... One system for one university and another system for another university does not work."

Reacting to Adhikari's statement, senior Trinamool Congress leader Kunal Ghosh said that the BJP was planning to subvert the Constitutional provisions earmarked for the minority institutions. "If there are separate educational institutions, they are not illegal because they have been provisioned by the Constitution of India, which guarantees minorities' right to follow, practice and profess their own religions and run their own religious institutions along with educational set-up... This Government is trying to create a communal divide to suit its political agenda."

Incidentally former Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya too had once questioned the secret activities inside the unaffiliated Madarsas of the State saying many of them were breeding grounds for antinationalist forces.

Kishor demands white paper on Ram temple

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gayaji (Bihar)

Jan Suraa Party founder Prashant Kishor on Friday urged the Narendra Modi Government at the Centre to bring out a 'white paper' on alleged financial irregularities in Ayodhya's Ram Temple and "fix accountability".

Speaking to reporters in the central Bihar town of Gayaji, Kishor also waded into the controversy over GDP figures, alleging that hardships suffered by the people belied the claims of a high growth rate by the Government.

The I-PAC founder, who had started off as a poll strategist handling Modi's election campaign in 2014, was asked about the appointment of Air Marshal (Retd) Jeetendra Mishra as the CEO of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

The Indian Air Force veteran's appointment as the first CEO of the trust comes in the wake of allegations of massive corruption in the management of the temple, the construction of which, after decades-long legal battle, is touted by the Modi Government as one of its major achievements.

"What will merely appointing a CEO achieve if the people who were previously involved in managing the affairs are let off the hook? Allegations of corruption have hurt the religious sentiments of the people. The Government must bring out a white paper on the financial irregularities that have taken place," Kishor said.



The Bankipur MLA was also asked about the raging debate that has been triggered by averments of former Union finance secretary Shrivani Kumar Garg on GDP figures. "The questions on projected GDP figures have been raised by a specialist. And this is not the first time that the Government's claims of GDP growth rate have been disputed," he said.

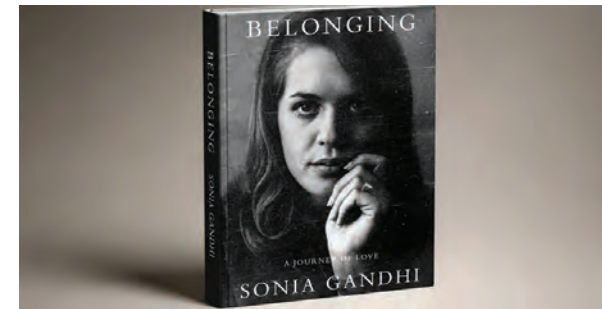
"The fact remains – a majority of the country's population is facing extreme hardships in their day-to-day lives. Abject poverty and joblessness fly in the face of the Government's claims that we are one of the fastest growing economies and the third-largest in the world. Unless the living standards of the people improve, questions will be raised on the Government's claims," the opposition legislator said. Kishor, who has firmly ruled out the possibility of an alliance with mainstream parties like the Congress, also asserted that "the Jan Suraa Party is committed to bringing a fundamental change in the way politics is done in Bihar".

HarperCollins to publish Sonia Gandhi's memoir on November 10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

HarperCollins India on Friday said it will publish Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's memoir "Belonging: A Journey of Love" in India on November 10, ending the uncertainty over the book's domestic publication following an "impasse" between the author's representatives and Penguin Random House India.

"One of the most anticipated political memoirs of our time, Belonging is a dramatic and deeply personal story of love, identity, duty and belonging, and offers a rare insider's view of India's journey," HarperCollins India said in a statement.



HarperCollins India's announcement follows a controversy involving Penguin Random House India (PRHI), which was initially keen to publish the memoir but subsequently said it would not be the Indian publisher. The controversy began amid reports of differences between the publisher and the author's

representatives over editorial changes to the manuscript.

With HarperCollins India now set to publish the memoir domestically, the book will be available in India alongside its international release on November 10 by Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of Penguin Random House.

Bihar's dharti pakad, who contested polls against Indira and Atal, dies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhagalpur

Nagarmal Bajoria, a Bihar businessman known for contesting nearly 300 elections, has died at the ripe age of 97, his family said on Friday.

According to close family members, the Bhagalpur resident, who boasted of having challenged former prime ministers Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi on their home turfs of Rae Bareilly and Amethi, respectively, breathed his last at a hospital in Patna on Thursday, following prolonged illness.

His body was brought to Bhagalpur, where last rites were performed on Friday.

Hailing from western Punjab, which now falls in Pakistan, Bajoria was among the millions of refugees who fled their homes during the horrific communal violence that marked the Partition.



Nagarmal Bajoria

After settling down in the east Bihar town, which in those days was known for a thriving textile industry, Bajoria is said to have decided to make himself count in the nascent republic

by becoming the proverbial perennial candidate, thereby earning the epithet "dharti pakad".

"He contested close to 300 elections, insisting every time that he wanted to raise

public awareness that polls were about the people and not power", said Gaurav, a grandson of Bajoria.

Gaurav recalled his grandfather contesting the 2005 Bihar Assembly polls, when the RJD was voted out of power, "donning clothes on which anti-corruption slogans were printed, and an old wristwatch proudly claimed to date back to the times of Mahatma Gandhi."

"My grandfather never joined a political party and first contested a municipal election in 1960. Of course, he came to be known across the country nine years later when he filed nomination papers for the Presidential poll, which was won by VV Giri," Gaurav said.

Apart from the Gandhis, other prominent leaders against whom Bajoria contested included former prime minister Atal Bihari

Vajpayee, his deputy Lal Krishna Advani and former president Pranab Mukherji.

Old residents recall Bajoria "making headlines by hitting the campaign trail with placards inscribed with names of well-known politicians placed around the necks of donkeys. He was also known to distribute dry fruits among the people".

Age eventually caught up with Bajoria, whose last widely discussed electoral venture was filing nomination papers for the 2012 Presidential election.

"His refrain used to be – it is not I who loses elections, it is the people who are losing every time. He wanted to contest the 2024 Lok Sabha polls from more than one seat, with Patna Sahib and Rae Bareilly being his preferred constituencies. But failing health came in the way," Gaurav said.

BJP MP accuses Punjab Police of custodial torture of Sikh youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh on Friday urged the National Human Rights Commission to take suo motu cognisance of the alleged custodial torture of a Sikh youth, who waved a black flag at a programme of the Punjab chief minister.

Chugh requested the human rights body to send an independent fact-finding team to the village where the incident took place and the police station concerned, and direct registration of an FIR against the officers involved, including the deputy superintendent of police.

He also sought high-level security and medical assistance for the victim and his family, alleging that they face serious threats from the State machinery.

In a letter to National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) member Priyank Kanoongo, Chugh, who is also the BJP national headquarters in-charge, alleged



BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh

that a local youth, Mohanjeet Singh, was arrested and subjected to brutal custodial torture after he waved a black flag at Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's programme in Sheron village on September 2 to protest against the AAP Government's handling of drug menace.

Singh was subjected to brutality "reminiscent of medieval-era torture", Chugh said, adding that he was stripped naked and beaten in custody.

The youth's thighs were cut with a blade, salt was rubbed onto his bleeding wounds,

and he was subjected to repeated electric shocks, the MP claimed.

"I am writing to urgently and immediately draw your attention to a deeply disturbing and horrific incident of alleged State-sponsored custodial torture in Punjab, which has completely shaken the conscience of our democratic society," Chugh wrote.

"The brutal treatment allegedly meted out to a young citizen by Punjab Police not only violates fundamental human rights but also represents a dark day for democracy and the rule of law in the state," he added.

Quoting the youth's revelation to the media, Chugh said that when the youngster was being stripped and assaulted, police officials made a video call.

"The officials allegedly showed the youth's naked, bloodied, and agonised condition to the caller. If true, this would indicate the direct involvement and sadistic complicity of the highest executive office of the State machinery," he said.

The BJP leader also alleged that police officials forcibly opened the youth's "joora" (hair knot) and pulled his beard and hair, describing it as an attack on his Sikh identity and religious sentiments.

In addition to this, a DSP-rank officer tortured and humiliated the youth's elderly mother and sister, the BJP leader said.

"We cannot allow our State to become a police State, where young people are subjected to torture and humiliation for raising their voice against drugs," he said, demanding action.

Karnataka CM Shivakumar seeks Union Govt's help on farm loan waiver, defends Parks Bill withdrawal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday urged the Union Govt to waive farm loans in the State amid the drought situation and called on BJP leaders to join him in pressing the demand in New Delhi.

The CM also defended his Government's decision to withdraw the contentious Parks Bill, which allows five per cent of park and garden land to be used for public infrastructure and utility projects, saying the move was meant to facilitate a debate and make people aware of its objectives. He criticised the BJP for claiming victory over the Bill's withdrawal, calling the party "anti-development" and saying it was responsible for any "curse" facing Bengaluru. "You have seen the BJP and JD(S)' politics. There was no discussion on farmers and the drought situation during the recent legislature session. That's the reason the special session has been called," Shivakumar said ahead of his



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar

visit to drought-affected areas in Bagalkote and Vijayanagar districts.

Speaking to reporters, he said BJP and JD(S) legislators had themselves expressed displeasure over the lack of an opportunity to discuss the drought situation during the recently concluded monsoon session, adding that ruling Congress legislators had voiced similar concerns.

"I want to help them. The central Government should also provide funds. There is a need to take an all-party delegation. BJP state president BY Vijayendra has demanded a farm loan waiver. The central Government should take responsibility for the farm

loan waiver, as the prime minister himself said that this is a drought," he said, urging Vijayendra and Leader of Opposition R Ashoka to join him in Delhi to press the demand, since the union Government had control over the matter.

The State legislature's special session has been convened from September 21 to 23 to discuss the drought situation, the related agrarian crisis and the Kasturirangan report on the proposed Western Ghats eco-sensitive zone.

Responding to Opposition criticism branding him "U-turn Shivakumar" over the Bill's withdrawal, the CM denied doing any U-turn.

Govt trying to build consensus on restricting DJs, says Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday said the State Government is working to build a consensus on restricting the use of high-decibel DJ systems during festivals and called for a return to traditional ways of celebrating.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of a programme in Pune, Fadnavis condemned the assault on an activist in the city and said he had spoken to the Pune police commissioner and there appeared to be broad agreement among stakeholders on curbing excessive sound systems that inconvenience people.

Vidyanand Bapat, an activist who has been vocal against the use of DJs and loudspeakers during festivals and was campaigning against noise pollution during Ganeshotsav, was assaulted on Thursday while speaking to a television news channel on Tilak Road in Pune.

"I have already condemned yesterday's incident. There can be different points of view, and people can be on either side, but violence is not right. Everyone



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis

should put forward their views," he said.

Festivals acquire greater significance when celebrated traditionally, but practices developed over the years cannot be eliminated only through legal action, he noted.

"Law has to be used; otherwise such practices cannot be stopped. But along with that, it is more important to take people into confidence and find a way forward," Fadnavis said.

He further likened the vibration of high-powered DJ setups to an "earthquake", but said that a Statewide policy on the issue would

not be framed immediately, as the Government was first pursuing discussions with stakeholders.

"Our experience is that wherever discussions have been held, 90 to 95 per cent of people agree. Therefore, this has to happen through discussion and, once that is done, a policy can be framed and an order issued," he said.

The process will take time, but the Government's direction was clear, he said.

"The direction is clear. We have to move towards traditional celebrations or at least move away from the very high level of noise pollution," the chief minister said.

9 newborns evacuated as fire erupts in Maharashtra hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Nine newborns were shifted after a fire broke out in the NICU (Neonatal Intensive Care Unit) of a private hospital in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar in the early hours of Friday, the hospital administration said.

The incident occurred at Asian Hospital located in the Jalna Road area of the city in the State's Marathwada region, officials said.

Nine babies, in need of intensive or specialised



medical care, were in the NICU when the staff noticed smoke coming out of an AC unit, said Dr Shueb Hashmi,

who runs the hospital. "It was a small incident, and nothing untoward happened. As a precaution, our

team evacuated the infants along with the patients in the neighbouring general ward," he said. The general ward patients were brought back later, he said.

The doctor said that the newborns were shifted to other hospitals with the consent of their families.

"The hospital team took immediate action and brought the situation under control. There were injuries in the incident. The hospital has been cleaned and is functioning as per its routine," he said.

When contacted, the in-charge officer at Jawaharnagar police station said, "A fire incident was reported to us. There were no injuries or casualties in the incident."

About ten days ago, three newborns died, and 36 were rescued after a devastating fire broke out in the NICU of the District Women's Hospital in Amravati in the neighbouring Vidarbha region, prompting the State Government to order a high-level inquiry into the tragedy.

JD(U) opposes renewal of Ganga treaty with Bangladesh, cites Bihar's interests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The ruling JD(U) in Bihar on Friday opposed the renewal of the Ganga water treaty with Bangladesh, saying the agreement conflicts with the State's interests.

JD(U) State president Umesh Kushwaha said the party's stand was in line with the position taken by former chief minister Nitish Kumar, asserting that the concerns of the state's people must be taken into account if the treaty is renewed.

"Our leader Nitish Kumar has always spoken against the treaty. Now, as the term

of the agreement is about to end, our stand is clear that it should not be renewed as it hampers the interests of people of Bihar," Kushwaha told reporters at the party headquarters.

The Ganga water treaty, also known as the Farakka water-sharing treaty, is a 30-year agreement signed by India and Bangladesh on December 12, 1996, to regulate the sharing of dry-season water flows at the Farakka Barrage.

Kushwaha blamed the then Bihar Government led by Lalu Prasad and the Deve Gowda-led Centre for allegedly failing to take into account



JD(U) State president Umesh Kushwaha

the concerns of the people of the State while the treaty was signed.

He said silt accumulation on the Indian side of the Farakka Barrage leads to excess water which, when

diverted to other streams, causes flooding and destruction in Bihar.

"The State has been braving the vagaries of deluge for decades, but now we are committed to putting

the concerns of people of Bihar on the international stage," Kushwaha said.

He also announced that he, JD(U) working president Sanjay Kumar Jha and other party leaders would undertake a "Nitish Samvad Yatra" from Saturday.

The yatra will begin in Buxar and cover 12 districts along the Ganga before culminating in Katihar, Kushwaha said.

"The route of Nitish Samvad Yatra coincides with the trajectory of the Ganga in Bihar. We will talk with people, take stock of the situation and their grievances," he said.

Farmers body urges MSP law, announces statewide protest against Mekedatu Dam from September 20

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Chennai

The Coordination Committee of All Farmers' Associations of Tamil Nadu on Friday announced a massive five-day Statewide campaign from September 20 to protest the Karnataka Government's attempt to construct a dam across the Cauvery at Mekedatu.

President of the farmers' body, PR Pandian, made this announcement following a detailed, five-hour meeting between a farmers' delegation and Union Minister of Power Manohar Lal Khattar



File Photo

in Gurugram. Accusing Karnataka's political leadership of pushing the Mekedatu project for political gain despite local opposition, Pandian stated that farmers will seek an audience with the prime minister, if neces-

sary, to press their demands after the campaign that will start at Poompohar.

While speaking to reporters, he strongly objected to the proposed dam across the River Cauvery, terming the Detailed Project Report (DPR) submitted by Karnataka to the Central Water Commission (CWC) as "fraudulent" and legally invalid. He noted the DPR lacks the requisite consent from Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA).

Urging the Central Government to deny any

environmental or forest clearance for the project, Pandian warned that the dam would be detrimental to farmers in both Tamil Nadu and Karnataka. He stated that Karnataka farmers acknowledge that the dam would offer them no benefits due to its location deep in forested areas downstream of the Krishnarajasagara (KRS) dam.

"Building a dam at Mekedatu to store water under the guise of drinking water requirements during scarcity periods is unacceptable and will only ruin agri-culture," he stated.

The tourism department said Goa attracts visitors year-round and is seeking to promote the coastal State as a year-round destination by showcasing monsoon, hinterland, heritage, cultural, and experiential tourism. The average duration of stay is approximately nine days for international tourists and three to four days for domestic visitors, it said.

Tourism is a major contributor to Goa's economy, with its direct contribution estimated at 16.43 per cent of the state's Gross Domestic Product, according to the Government.

Goa sees sharp rise in tourist arrivals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa has recorded a sharp increase in tourist arrivals over the past five years, with the number of domestic visitors rising from about 70.19 lakh in 2022 to over 1.02 crore in 2025, while international arrivals crossed the five lakh mark last year, the State Government told the Legislative Assembly.

According to the data tabled by Tourism Minister Rohan Khaunte during the recently held monsoon session of the Assembly, Goa recorded 70,18,945 domestic



and 1,69,005 international tourist arrivals in 2022.

The number of domestic tourists increased to 81,75,460 in 2023 and 99,41,285 in 2024, before reaching 1,02,84,608 in 2025, it said.

International arrivals also

rose from 4,52,702 in 2023 to 4,67,911 in 2024 and 5,17,802 in 2025. In the first seven months of 2026, Goa recorded 59,01,769 domestic and 2,36,113 international tourist arrivals, taking the total to more than 61.37 lakh.

Release Nagarjuna Sagar water or I will march again: KTR warns Telangana Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

BRS Working President K T Rama Rao said he would undertake a padayatra from Kodad to Haliya with thousands of farmers if the Telangana Government failed to announce a schedule for releasing water into the Nagarjuna Sagar Left Canal by September 14.

Alleging that the Congress Government was withholding water from the Left Canal despite around 180 TMC being available in the Nagarjuna Sagar project, Rama Rao, also known as KTR, said farmers were anxious about their crops.

"If the Government does not announce a clear water-release schedule by September 14, I will personally undertake a padayatra from Kodad to Haliya with thousands of farmers," he said, demanding that the Government immediately announce a detailed plan specifying when water would reach farmers.

He recalled that his father and BRS president K Chandrasekhara Rao had undertaken a similar padayatra (foot march) from Kodad to Haliya in Nalgonda district in 2003 in support of farmers dependent on the Left Canal, successfully pressuring the



BRS Working President KT Rama Rao

then Government to resolve their water woes. He said he was prepared to launch a similar agitation now.

Addressing an event in Miryalguda in Nalgonda district on Thursday evening, Rama Rao said the Nagarjuna Sagar command area, which had flourished under the BRS Government and contributed significantly to Telangana's agricultural growth, was facing a severe crisis, leaving farmers across the Left Canal command area uncertain about water for their crops.

He attacked the Congress Government over unfulfilled poll promises on farm loan waivers, financial assistance and crop bonuses.

Countering Rama Rao, Congress MLA Beerla Ilaiah told reporters on Friday that irrigation projects in Nalgonda district, including modernisation works on the Left Canal, had been ignored under the previous BRS regime, and that people would not trust the BRS even if Rama Rao undertook a padayatra or similar agitation.

Ilaiah said the State Government was prioritising drinking water supply in view of deficient rainfall attributed to El Nino and alleged that Rama Rao was resorting to agitations as he was "unable to digest the popularity of the Congress Government", which had recently completed 1,000 days in office.

Flood-like situation in 5 Bihar districts as rivers breach danger mark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Five districts in Bihar have been experiencing a flood-like situation as several rivers flowed above their danger marks in the State following incessant rainfall in the upper riparian nation of Nepal and in the neighbouring State of Jharkhand.

With the swelled Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, Punpun and Ghaghra rivers inundating several places, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducted an aerial survey of the affected areas on Friday and reviewed relief and rescue operations.

In a post on X, the chief minister said, "I instructed officials to take swift and effective action to ensure that the public in the affected areas receives all possible assistance promptly, faces no difficulties, and that the safety of lives and property is ensured."



Editor's

TAKE

India must fix its own classrooms

Can India truly aspire to become a Vishwa Guru when it continues to grapple with teacher shortages, overcrowding and inadequate learning outcomes?

Every September 5, India honours Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan - philosopher, Oxford scholar, and the Republic's first Vice-President and second President. When students proposed celebrating his birthday after he became President in 1962, he asked instead that the date be observed as Teachers' Day, insisting teachers deserved to rank among the nation's finest minds. It is a fitting origin story for a country that has long seen itself as a wellspring of learning for the world.

That reverence is not sentimental excess. Teachers do more than deliver a syllabus; they build the cognitive and moral scaffolding on which every other profession stands. The doctor who saves a life, the engineer who builds a bridge, the officer who frames policy - all once sat before a teacher who taught them to reason, question and persist. In a country of 1.4 billion, no institution shapes the future more directly than the classroom, nor any individual more than the teacher standing in it.

India's claim to Vishwa Guru status - teacher to the world - rests on genuine civilisational memory. Nalanda and Takshashila once drew scholars from Persia to China; the guru-shishya tradition treated teaching as a sacred trust, not a fallback career.

Reviving that stature is now stated national ambition, invoked from foreign-policy platforms to soft-power strategy. Ground reality is more sobering. A Parliamentary Standing Committee last year counted close to ten lakh vacant teaching posts under the Centre's Samagra Shiksha scheme - over seven lakh of them at the primary and elementary level. Vacancies for secondary and senior-secondary teachers, precisely where subject expertise matters most, nearly doubled within a single year.

Regulators have simultaneously derecognised scores of teacher-training colleges that had reduced the B.Ed degree to a paper formality. Even the good news carries a warning: the most recent ASER survey, in 2024, found barely a quarter of Class 3 government-school children could read a Class 2-level text - a real improvement on 2022, but still a low bar for an aspiring Vishwa Guru.

Add chronically underpaid contract teachers, overcrowded classrooms and patchy in-service training, and the gap between rhetoric and classroom is hard to ignore.

Vishwa Guru cannot be built on borrowed civilisational glory alone. It has to be built teacher by teacher - through fair pay, rigorous training, manageable classrooms, and recruitment drives that fill vacancies before ministries announce new schemes.

Teachers' Day should not be a 24-hour ritual that gives way, on September 6, to indifference about who is actually at the blackboard. The country would do well to remember that the surest way to teach the world is to first take proper care of those who teach it at home.

-DAIV



ABHISHEK ANAND

A nation that reveres its educators progresses on the path of growth and development. As we cruise towards the centenary of independence and our lofty goal of becoming *Viksit Bharat@2047*, it is worth pondering and exploring how ancient Indian wisdom and civilisational ethos, encapsulated in the *Taittiriya Upanisad*'s injunction "*Acharya devo bhava*" (regard the teacher as divine), on the teacher being supremely esteemed, who was looked upon not only as an instructor but as a spiritual and moral guide, remain profoundly and significantly relevant even today.

Ancient Indian education and the Guru-Shishya Parampara

The ancient Indian education system was a disciplined process of intellectual, moral and spiritual formation; not merely of inculcating the ability to read, write and calculate. It was anchored in the *Guru-Shishya Parampara*. Centres of learning assumed and developed different institutional forms, such as Taxila and Nalanda, over many centuries. At these, the *acharya/guru* was often more than a disseminator of information and knowledge. They mediated an intellectual inheritance and shaped the character, conduct and judgement of their pupils. Radha Kumud Mookerji's classic study, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist* (1947), remains the landmark scholarly account of how this teacher-centred model carried the essence of "Indianness" for over a millennium. Similarly, Hartmut Scharfe's *Education in Ancient India* (2002) illuminates the centrality of oral transmission, memorisation, debate, apprenticeship and the close teacher-student bond in this long history.

The *Upanishads* express this relationship with unusual clarity. The *Chhandogya Upanishad* compares an ignorant person to someone left blindfolded in an unfamiliar land; once shown the direction, they can ask their way and reach their destination. The tutor does not walk every step for the tutee; they remove the blindfold, give direction and enable intelligent inquiry. Its conclusion (6.14.2) is striking:

"A person who has a teacher comes to know."

The *Taittiriya Upanisad* goes further by presenting education as a moral compass. In the celebrated instruction to a departing student, the pedagogue says:

"Speak the truth. Practise Dharma. Do not neglect self-study."

These simple words carry substantial weight



THE ANCIENT INDIAN EDUCATION SYSTEM WAS A DISCIPLINED PROCESS OF INTELLECTUAL, MORAL AND SPIRITUAL FORMATION; NOT MERELY OF INCULCATING THE ABILITY TO READ, WRITE AND CALCULATE. IT WAS ANCHORED IN THE GURU-SHISHYA PARAMPARA. CENTRES OF LEARNING ASSUMED AND DEVELOPED DIFFERENT INSTITUTIONAL FORMS, SUCH AS TAXILA AND NALANDA, OVER MANY CENTURIES

The writer is a Senior Research Fellow at Bharat Ki Soch

during an individual's formative years: the most crucial stage of their life's journey. Bharat's young population must be cognisant of the Indian education model's enduring trajectory, which was not restricted to textual learning. The *Gurukulas*, where students and their *guru* lived together, influenced and moulded it. The former observed the latter's daily living and learned from his conduct. Teachers can help cultivate in students the enduring values of patience, perseverance, tolerance, wisdom, compassion, empathy, truthfulness, honesty, sincerity and righteousness.

Guru as the fourth deity

The *Taittiriya Upanisad*'s *Shikshavali*, in its convocation address to graduating students, articulates (1.11.2):

"Let your mother be a God to you. Let your father be a God to you. Let your teacher be a God to you. Let your guest be a God to you."

This matters for Teachers' Day because, in Indian tradition, respect for teachers was tied to the gravity of their responsibility. Reverence was not merely ceremonial status; the teacher was considered an epitome of knowledge because education concerned truth, duty, self-control, perseverance and respect for his *guru*.

Teachers as the cultivators of civil Order

Educators can infuse civic discipline and compliance by making the classroom a living school of responsible citizenship. Through their own punctuality, fairness, honesty, respectful conduct and adherence to rules, they can show that discipline is not blind obedience but the voluntary exercise of self-control in the interest of the common good. Like a potter's hands create shapely vessels from shapeless clay, they can effectively make students frame and follow norms of punctu-

ality in life, respectful speech, integrity, cleanliness, digital conduct, regard for elders and care for public property. At the same time, classroom discussions, debates and service activities can teach pupils to respect differences, accept accountability and translate constitutional values into daily action. In this way, they can nurture young citizens who are lawful without being unthinking, patriotic without being intolerant and free without being irresponsible; citizens whose honesty, civic-mindedness, environmental consciousness, respect for institutions and commitment to excellence will strengthen Bharat's social fabric and advance the building of a strong, robust, *Atma-Nirbhar* and *Viksit Bharat*.

The guru-shishya legacy in NEP 2020

The New Education Policy (NEP) 2020 redefines education not only as literacy, numeracy and professional competence, but also as critical thinking, constitutional values, ethical responsibility, scientific temper and a commitment to fundamental duties. In doing so, it seeks to revive the timeless Indian ideal of *Vidya Dana*, where education is a sacred trust that nurtures both individual excellence and collective welfare. By rooting learning in civilisational continuity while embracing modern innovation, it positions educators as the moral and intellectual anchors of this enhanced vision. It states, "The teacher must be at the centre of the fundamental reforms" and calls for the restoration of teachers' "respect, dignity and autonomy". It envisions them not merely as disseminators of subject knowledge but as facilitators of holistic learning, imparting life skills and socio-cultural-emotional intelligence. Hence, their roles and functions acquire a new dimension in reimagining Bharat's advancement.

Conclusion

Beyond other determinants, a *Viksit Bharat* will also be ascertained and measured by the quality of its human resources and civic culture. Teachers are uniquely placed to make this transition real and transformative. They can encourage young Indians to move away from the question, "What can the country give me?" to a more meaningful and equally pressing question: "What can I contribute to the country?" This self-introspection and self-reflection are not merely rhetoric. When instilled successfully, they will be seen in the collective endeavour of Indian citizens working towards nation-building by voluntarily practising responsibility, restraint, lawfulness, rule-following and concern for the greater good. In this way, our respected teachers can help achieve a *Viksit Bharat* by enabling millions of Indians to perform civic responsibilities towards the nation with a profound sense of purpose and sincerity.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University, a civil engineer, a short-story writer and a columnist

Living with time: The impermanence of infrastructure



SIDDHARTH ROY

2ND OPINION

A crack in a concrete wall is called a defect. An engineer sees something deeper: a message from time. It tells us that materials age and even strong structures exist within design limits. Civil engineering, therefore, is more than construction. It is an encounter with impermanence.

Every structure carries the certainty of deterioration. Concrete weathers, steel corrodes, roads develop potholes, bridges experience fatigue, dams accumulate sediment and foundations settle. We celebrate a bridge or highway, photograph the ribbon-cutting and then overlook the quieter responsibility: maintenance.

No bridge is permanent. A design life of 50, 75 or 100 years is not a promise of immortality. It is an engineer-

ing expectation based on loads, materials, environment, usage and maintenance. A structure survives because people inspect it, repair it, strengthen it and eventually replace it. Durability is not the absence of decay; it is our ability to respond intelligently to decay.

This is also a philosophical lesson for society. We celebrate creation more readily than preservation. A new expressway attracts headlines; routine resurfacing rarely does. A spectacular bridge becomes a symbol of progress; replacing corroded reinforcement does not. Political incentives favour visible construction because new projects can be inaugurated, while maintenance produces no ceremony.

The consequences follow. Deferred maintenance transforms manageable deterioration into expensive reconstruction. A small crack can allow water to reach reinforcement; corrosion can weaken structural members; weakness can eventually become failure. What engineering teaches us about structures is equally applicable to institutions. Neglect rarely announces its consequences immediately. It accumulates silently until repair becomes unavoidable.

Engineers design for uncertainty. We calculate loads, estimate probabilities and provide safety margins because the future cannot be known precisely. Yet societies often demand certainty from infrastructure. We expect drainage systems to cope with unprecedented rainfall, roads to withstand changing traffic and bridges to remain safe indefinitely. Climate

change makes such assumptions increasingly dangerous. Infrastructure designed around yesterday's climate may confront tomorrow's extremes.

The answer is not to stop building. It is to build with humility. A mature engineering culture must ask not only, "Can we construct this?" but also, "Can we maintain it for generations?" Life-cycle costs should matter as much as construction costs. Materials should be selected for durability and repairability. Infrastructure agencies need regular inspections, accurate asset registers, trained personnel and protected maintenance budgets. Resilience must become a design principle, not merely an emergency response.

There is something profoundly human in our relationship with imperfection. We build knowing that everything we construct will eventually age. A bridge may serve millions for a century and still disappear one day. Its value lies not in defeating time, but in serving people while it stands. Perhaps civilisation is not measured by how successfully it conquers time. It is measured by how intelligently it lives with time.

The crack is not merely a failure. It is a reminder that everything built by human hands requires care and that permanence was never the bargain.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University, a civil engineer, a short-story writer and a columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Lesson from the flood tragedy

The disaster on the Nepal-Tibet border demonstrated the fragility of the Himalayan ecosystem and human vulnerability to natural disasters. The frequency, intensity and scale of floods, landslides and glacial lake outbursts in the Himalayan region bespeak a crisis of frightening proportions. The Himalayan region is topographically, ecologically and geologically fragile. Climate change occurring in the Himalayas twice as fast as the global average makes the region all the more precarious and prone to disasters. So-called developmental activities also contribute to vulnerability to disasters. Unplanned construction, deforestation, road expansion and other interventions can disturb the region's delicate ecological balance and increase risks to communities living in vulnerable areas.

As a geographical entity, the Himalayas have no national borders and form a single entity, and they need to be managed, protected and secured for safety through the collective efforts of all nations in the region, especially Nepal, India and China. This requires regional cooperation, scientific knowledge-sharing, early-warning systems, disaster preparedness and sustainable development. Protecting the Himalayan ecosystem is essential not only for the safety of mountain communities but also for millions downstream.

G DAVID MILTON | TAMIL NADU

Teachers who shape young lives

There are teachers whose words remain with us long after we leave the classroom. Their influence becomes part of who we are. A teacher may teach a subject, but a true teacher teaches us how to face life. Student life is filled with dreams, confusion, hopes, failures and questions. At such a stage, teachers become guides who help students understand their abilities and discover their purpose. Behind many confident individuals is a teacher who once said, "You can do it" when they had stopped believing in themselves. Every student is different. Some excel academically, while others are creative or take time to discover their strengths. A caring teacher recognises potential and encourages students to grow at their own pace. Simple appreciation can inspire confidence. Teachers also teach honesty, discipline, patience, kindness, responsibility, respect and compassion. Marks measure achievement, but values shape character.

Teachers do not simply prepare students for examinations. They prepare them for life. They shape minds, build character, nurture dreams and give direction to young lives. On Teachers' Day, we celebrate a relationship that can last a lifetime. Behind every student who dares to dream, there is often a teacher who first taught them to believe.

NISARGA | UTTAR PRADESH

A practical path to cleaner steel

This refers to the article "India's steel sector and decarbonisation" (September 4). The proposed effort to reduce emission intensity in the iron and steel sector is an important step, given the industry's central role in India's economic growth. Steel will remain essential for infrastructure, housing and manufacturing, but its expansion cannot ignore the environmental cost of carbon-intensive production. The transition, however, must be practical and carefully designed. Different steel plants operate with varying technologies and levels of efficiency. A uniform approach may create difficulties for smaller producers. Emission targets should therefore be accompanied by realistic timelines, technological support and access to affordable finance.

The government should encourage cleaner production, energy efficiency, scrap-based manufacturing and technologies such as green hydrogen. Reliable emission monitoring and verification are equally important. Small and medium enterprises need financial and technical support for a smooth transition. India should view decarbonisation as an opportunity to strengthen industrial competitiveness through a clear and predictable policy framework.

K PALANIYAPPAN | CHENNAI

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Bones That Saved the World

The Devas were losing their long war against the Demon Vritra, who could not be killed by any ordinary weapon. Only one thing could defeat him - a weapon made from the bones of a Sage who had willingly given up his body in service of others. The Devas approached the Sage Dadhichi, who lived a simple life of penance, and asked for exactly that.

Dadhichi did not hesitate, did not bargain, did not ask what he would gain. He gave up his life so that his bones could be shaped into the Vajra, the thunderbolt with which Indra finally defeated Vritra and restored peace to the three worlds. He asked for nothing in return - not gratitude, not remembrance, not even a place in the stories that would later be told about him.

We often measure generosity by what we can spare - old clothes, spare change, a little free time. Dadhichi's story asks a harder question: *what would we give if it truly cost us something?*

Seva does not always demand such extremes. But it does demand the same spirit - giving without calculating the return, without needing to be seen, without asking what remains for us afterward. Today, do one thing for someone that asks nothing in return, not even their thanks.

-DAIV

PIC TALK



Devotees offer prayers during Krishna Janmashtami celebrations at the ISKCON temple in Dream City, on the outskirts of Jammu

PHOTO: PTI

The SCO and the illusion of moral multipolarity

As the organisation evolves from a regional security forum into an ambitious network spanning finance, technology, energy and connectivity, its growing influence must be judged not by its opposition to Western dominance, but by the same standards of power, accountability and equality it demands of the West



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

China's rise is real. The SCO's institutional expansion is real. The erosion of the old assumption of uncontested Western primacy is real. But the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Bishkek last week has once again confirmed that global politics is moving away from the old assumption that one power can organise the international system largely on its own terms. The SCO also insisted that it is not a military bloc and does not seek bloc confrontation. Yet beneath the familiar diplomatic language lies a more consequential development. The organisation is no longer merely a forum in which China, Russia, India, Iran, Pakistan and the Central Asian republics discuss security. Its 28 outcome documents extend cooperation into counterterrorism, narcotics, information security, artificial intelligence, computing infrastructure, ports and logistics, energy, climate, biodiversity, nuclear security, emergency assistance and cultural cooperation. The SCO is becoming an institutional network, and that makes it far more significant than the slogan of a new multipolar world suggests.

But there is a problem with the triumphalism surrounding this transformation. A world with several centres of power is not automatically a fairer world. Multipolarity describes the distribution of power; it does not determine how that power is used. This distinction is frequently lost in the political language surrounding the SCO. Western military intervention, sanctions, financial coercion and double standards deserve criticism where the evidence warrants it. Opposition to Western power is legitimate. But the fact that Washington has abused economic and military power in particular circumstances does not give Beijing, Moscow or anyone else a licence to exercise their own power without scrutiny.

The history of the SCO explains why this question matters. The organisation emerged from the Shanghai Five in 1996, when China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan sought to manage border disputes and build confidence after the collapse of the Soviet Union. Uzbekistan joined in 2001, and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation was formally created. Its subsequent expansion changed its scale. India and Pakistan joined in 2017, followed by Iran in 2023 and Belarus in 2024. Calling such a collection an anti-Western alliance is analytically lazy. It is more accurately understood as a mechanism through which states with very different interests can cooperate without accepting a single political centre.

China's influence is more subtle and, in some respects, more consequential. Beijing has spent decades converting economic strength into structural influence. It has built trade relationships, financed infrastructure, expanded industrial investment, supplied telecommunications equipment, developed transport corridors and increased its role in energy and technology. In Central Asia, the Chinese presence is no longer confined to imported consumer goods or large infrastructure projects. It is increasingly entering productive sectors. A Chinese-backed fertiliser plant in Kyrgyzstan's Osh region, for example, is intended to produce hundreds of thousands of tonnes annually, potentially exceeding the country's current domestic requirement. Such a project can reduce Kyrgyzstan's dependence on imports and create genuine industrial capacity. It can also connect production, Chinese technology, distribution networks and regional transport corridors more deeply to China's economic system. Neither interpretation can be excluded.

China has become an extraordinary export power and continues to run enormous trade surpluses. Chinese manufacturing has produced competitive machinery, electronics, electric vehicles, batteries, renewable-energy equipment and industrial products on a scale few countries can match. Developing countries buy Chinese goods because they often offer affordability and availability. That is not exploitation by definition. But neither is it evidence of equality. China's trade with Central Asia is heavily tilted towards Chinese exports. Chinese customs data put trade with the five Central Asian republics at more than \$100 billion in 2025, with China's exports substantially exceeding its imports. Discrepancies between Chinese and Central Asian trade statistics make the issue even more important because governments cannot properly negotiate equitable commercial relationships when basic figures are difficult to reconcile.



CHINA HAS BECOME AN EXTRAORDINARY EXPORT POWER AND CONTINUES TO RUN ENORMOUS TRADE SURPLUSES. CHINESE MANUFACTURING HAS PRODUCED COMPETITIVE MACHINERY, ELECTRONICS, ELECTRIC VEHICLES, BATTERIES, RENEWABLE-ENERGY EQUIPMENT AND INDUSTRIAL PRODUCTS ON A SCALE FEW COUNTRIES CAN MATCH. DEVELOPING COUNTRIES BUY CHINESE GOODS BECAUSE THEY OFTEN OFFER AFFORDABILITY AND AVAILABILITY

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

China's enormous trade surplus with the world presents the same contradiction on a larger scale. Beijing can legitimately argue that its exports reflect competitiveness and that weak domestic demand contributes to the surplus. It can also point to the enormous quantities of goods that developing economies have obtained at relatively low cost. But a persistent surplus on this scale means that other countries are, collectively, running the corresponding deficits. It cannot be defined as Chinese wrongdoing, but it is certainly evidence of an imbalance with consequential effects. If Western governments are criticised for using financial and economic asymmetries to pressure weaker states, the same intellectual standard must be applied if China uses its industrial capacity and market clout to manipulate target countries. There cannot be a duality in morality.

The SCO's proposed Development Bank exposes the gap between political ambition and institutional reality. Yet the Bishkek summit did not launch an operating bank. Kyrgyzstan wants to host it, while Kazakhstan has offered to host the headquarters. Fundamental questions concerning capital, membership, governance and location remain unresolved. That is not a trivial administrative delay. It demonstrates how difficult it is to convert declarations about financial autonomy into a functioning alternative financial institution. An alternative world financial system cannot be created by speeches about de-dollarisation. It requires capital, liquidity, credible governance, settlement mechanisms, investor confidence and institutions capable of surviving political disagreements.

The same caution should apply to claims about alternative payment systems. China's CIPS and Russia's SPFS can reduce dependence on Western financial infrastructure in particular transactions, and local-currency settlement can reduce exposure to the dollar. But neither system has displaced the global importance of the dollar, and neither has reproduced the depth and liquidity of the international financial architecture centred on dollar markets. It is perfectly reasonable for countries to seek protection against the political use of financial sanctions. It is unreasonable to pretend that an alternative system already exists when it remains incomplete. The SCO's economic future will be judged by what its institutions can actually finance, not by how strongly its communiqués denounce Western financial dominance.

There is another contradiction that the SCO cannot permanently avoid. It speaks of sovereignty and non-interference while involving itself in the political future of Afghanistan. It speaks of equality while containing countries whose economic and military capabilities are separated by enormous margins. It condemns double standards while its members themselves interpret terrorism, sovereignty and international law according to national interests. The treatment of Ukraine and Iran illustrates the difficulty. The Bishkek declaration adopted strong language concerning military strikes on Iran but did not mention Ukraine. India, China, Russia and the Central Asian states have different interests in the Ukraine conflict, and those differences prevent a common position. That is not necessarily hypocrisy. It is evidence that the SCO remains a coalition of interests rather than a unified geopolitical ideology.

This is why the debate about the SCO should not become another morality play in which the West is portrayed as the old imperial power and China, Russia and their partners as the innocent architects of liberation. History is rarely that simple. The United States and its allies have repeatedly used economic and military power in ways that deserve serious criticism. China has every right to oppose sanctions that it considers illegitimate. Russia has every right to argue against a Western monopoly over international decision-making. India has every right to resist pressure from any bloc. But every one of these countries must also answer for how it uses its own power. Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif returned to Islamabad last week with the SCO presidency, setting up a potentially decisive year for the organisation - and perhaps its most intriguing moment if he, or whoever is Prime Minister then, must decide whether to invite his Indian counterpart to Islamabad. A country does not become benign because its rival is worse.

Janmashtami: The idol, the Gita, and the mirror



ACHARYA
PRASHANT

The images arrive every year, each more elaborate than the last. A tiny Krishna is given admission to a school, taken for a heartbeat check, addressed as *mera laala*. Elsewhere, a human tower climbs a hundred feet so one young man can risk his neck to break a pot of curd and earn some merit.

A temple priest brought all this to me recently, a man who installs idols for a living. He asked a plain question: can such service, offered to the symbol, ever help in the melting away of the ego? Or has the deity himself become one more object of craving?

That question is the whole festival. It carries two Krishnas. One is fashioned: the butter-thief on his swing, dancing among the gopis, easy to remember, for he asks nothing of you. The other is the Krishna of the Gita, dangerous, asking for everything. Janmashtami remembers the first and forgets the second, because the second costs something.

Notice why the first wins so easily. The Ramcharitmanas is a chronicle of hardship, and almost nobody wants that today; the Bhagavat Puran asks little of your discernment. The miraculous image built around Krishna is the very thing that took the Gita away: once he is made into Kanha and laddu-gopal, the author of the Gita is nearly impossible to see in him. Stories and Krishna cannot run together; stories rise from the ego, and Krishna means its dissolution.

All of spirituality is for the ego, and the ego is a master of self-deception. Were it honest with itself, no method would be needed; your own honesty would be enough. Something outside is needed, then: a mirror, because one held inside the ego shows only what the ego wants to see. The idol is neither good nor bad; everything turns on who you are and what you intend. The ego's oldest instinct is self-preservation: it takes whatever it is handed, idol included, and turns it into one more way of staying exactly as it is.

What, then, was the idol for? To be a mirror. You stand before Krishna, before Ram, and something in you is meant to feel small. A prince who let go of his kingdom, wandered fourteen years, won a city of gold and walked away from that too; and here is a man who cannot give up half a gram of silver. You go to hand him a certificate. He has no use for your medals. Krishna is not doing this work; you are, or you are refusing to. Ask of your own visits: did one belief crack? Leave as you came, and nothing broke. Nothing was worship.

When the saints attacked idol-worship, this is what they meant. If worshipping stone could deliver God, said Kabir Saheb, I would worship a whole mountain. The contempt is not for the idol but for the ego that polishes a stone and will not look at its own unpolished state. They were never against the idol, but against the ego that eats everything: guru, scripture, idol, truth itself.

Murt does not mean stone. *Murt* is the manifested, whatever has form: the book, the word, the thought, the direction you face in prayer. The whole world is *murt*, and the very traditions that forbid idols still deal in it at every step. How, then, will you escape the idol when everything is an idol?

Krishna's own form is the Gita. The Krishna with form is a printed copy; the formless Krishna is its meaning. Krishna stands less in front of the eyes than behind them; the painted idol before you holds no power of its own. Krishna is *bodh*, an awakening; Krishna is Truth. Stand before his idol, and if the Gita does not rise in you, the idol has been misused. The temple may blaze with lamps, but if nothing lights in you, the worship went nowhere.

Krishna's life is contradiction upon contradiction, because *advaita* means all opposites held together. With Krishna there is no *maryada*. He is dangerous, and if living dangerously is beyond you, then living is beyond you. The Gita is for those with some fire still in them; for the ones gone to dust and ash, there are the sweets. *Peda*, sweet, is cheap; *peeda*, pain, is the price of the Gita.

Prem is not the ego's convenience of 'Radha and Krishna loved too,' but the melting of the ego. Let the intent curdle, and the same devotion turns: 'Krishna ate butter,' it is said, and the eye slides away from the modern dairy, where a calf's milk is stolen so the taste can go on. To give that cruelty the name of one who is an ocean of compassion is the deepest insult truth can take.

How, then, is Janmashtami to be kept? Keep it not as Krishna's birthday but as your own. Krishna is never born, for he never died; it is you who needs a birth, having never been born. Look, then, not toward Krishna but toward yourself. Walk into my own room and you will find more than twenty idols; they watch you and you watch them, and whether they are decorations or mirrors is a matter of intent, yours, not theirs. Why look for me outside, said Kabir Saheb, I am next to you. None of the saints was breaking idols; each was pointing at the one who hides behind them.

The idol should reach you not as comfort but as challenge, as rebellion, as fire. Something should break, and whether it breaks no one can decide for you, not even Krishna. The Gita's own word, simplified: 'He will not be born anywhere outside; the Lord appears within, if only you will do battle with yourself.' Decide once to live in the truth, and a strength rises of its own; that strength is what the name Krishna points to. Do not outsource your life to the idol; whatever strength you needed was given long ago. The trouble is not that you are bound, but that you are asleep and dreaming. Trust the idol later. No hour is fixed for this waking, and no lateness is possible in it. The turn is here now, as it always has been.



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

Weight of a school bag: India's children are still bearing a heavy burden, literally



SUNDEEP
BHUTORIA

It would be one thing if India had never recognised the problem. But we have. It has been studied, debated and translated into a national policy that even sets out how much a child should reasonably be expected to carry. The real question, then, is not whether we know the burden exists. It is why so many children are still carrying it.

India has around 24.72 crore school students across roughly 14.67 lakh schools. Even a seemingly mundane question such as backpack weight, therefore, becomes an issue of enormous scale.

During the exercise that led to the School Bag Policy, 2020, an overwhelming majority of responding parents said a heavy school bag was a serious problem for their child. The survey also showed how quickly the kilos accumulate. Textbooks could contribute anything from 500 grams to 3.5 kg, notebooks another 200 grams to 2.5 kg. Lunch boxes, water bottles and the empty bag itself add still more.

This is why calling it a 'bag problem' is slight-

ly misleading. The bag is merely the container. The real weight is created by decisions: how many subjects are taught on a day, how many notebooks each subject requires, whether supplementary books are prescribed, whether drinking water is readily available, whether books can remain in school, and whether every lesson necessarily requires a textbook to travel between home and classroom.

There is also a health case for being sensible, although we should resist exaggerating it. Singapore's public-health guidance similarly recommends keeping school bags around 10-15 per cent. India's own policy also calls for school bags themselves to be lightweight and ergonomically designed. That is important because reducing the burden is not simply about taking books out of a bag.

We have an implementation problem

A private member's Children School Bags (Limitation on Weight) Bill was introduced in the Rajya Sabha in 2006. It proposed limits on bag weight and storage facilities in schools, but the Bill eventually lapsed. More than a decade later, the Madras High Court directed the Centre to formulate a national policy. An expert group was constituted, and the Ministry of Education issued the School Bag Policy in November 2020 for implementation by States and Union Territories. Its recommendations are remarkably practical.

The 2018 judgment in *M Purushothaman v Union of India* was, in fact, the principal judicial impetus behind the national policy. The Madras High Court



asked the Union Government to frame a policy broadly on the models already being followed in Telangana and Maharashtra, ensure its adoption by all States and Union Territories, constitute special or flying squads for inspections, prevent schools from prescribing unnecessary books, and regulate subjects and homework in accordance with NCERT and National Curriculum Framework norms. In many respects, these directions anticipated what subsequently became the core of the School Bag Policy, 2020.

The judiciary returned to the issue in *Johny Cyriac v MHRD* before the Kerala High Court in 2020. That judgment reinforced the measures already underway, emphasising that they needed to be implemented "in letter and spirit" and backed by periodic inspections. Importantly, it also located excessive school burden within the wider framework of child rights and welfare, including Articles 21 and 39(e) and (f) of the Constitution.

The two interventions are worth reading together. The Madras High Court supplied the principal

push towards a national framework; the Kerala High Court underlined that having a framework on paper would mean little without effective implementation and monitoring.

As per the 2020 policy, there should be no school bags for pre-primary children. From Class I onwards, the suggested ceiling is approximately 10 per cent of the child's body weight. So, depending on the child's weight, the indicative range is about 1.6-2.2 kg for Classes I-II, rising progressively through the senior classes. Schools are expected to weigh bags periodically, rationalise textbooks and notebooks, and design timetables that reduce the number of materials travelling each day.

The policy goes further. It recommends no homework for Classes I-II; up to two hours a week for Classes III-V; around an hour a day for Classes VI-VIII; and up to two hours daily thereafter. Under the larger NEP framework, students in Grades VI-VIII are also meant to experience a 10-day 'bagless' period involving vocational and experiential learning. Dedicated guidelines for these bagless days were launched by the Education Ministry in 2024. What India needs is the less glamorous part of policymaking: implementation.

West Bengal issued fresh guidelines in May this year, setting the 10 per cent limit, requiring schools to display permissible weights and use weighing machines regularly. Chandigarh has gone a step further administratively: a five-member committee has been constituted to conduct quarterly inspections across government, aided and recognised private schools.

Maharashtra showed much earlier that moni-

toring can be done at scale. In 2016, the State informed the Bombay High Court that 2,463 officials had inspected 17,235 schools and checked 3,94,299 bags. It reported compliance of 87.45 per cent. What we need is relatively clear: put a weighing scale in every school, display the permissible range where parents and children can see it, conduct random checks, include one simple school-bag compliance measure within existing reporting systems, and ask schools to tell pupils in advance which books are actually required the next day. Small administrative changes can remove surprisingly large amounts of weight.

There should also be clear consequences for repeated non-compliance. At present, the larger challenge is that the School Bag Policy remains substantially an advisory framework. Stronger statutory or regulatory backing, accompanied by proportionate penalties or other regulatory action where schools repeatedly disregard the norms, would help ensure that implementation does not depend entirely on the enthusiasm of individual States, districts or school administrations.

The school bag can become a useful test of whether the philosophy of the National Education Policy is actually reaching the classroom. India has already decided what a reasonable school bag should weigh. Perhaps it is now time to weigh something else: how seriously we take our own policy.

The writer is a social activist working in the fields of welfare, international cultural cooperation, and the promotion and preservation of Indian arts, languages and culture



TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in



Order Order

Alcohol disclosure saves ₹50 lakh insurance claim



A Nagpur consumer commission has directed Edelweiss Tokio Life Insurance Company Ltd to pay ₹50 lakh to a widow after ruling that the insurer wrongly rejected her late husband's life insurance claim despite his having disclosed his alcohol consumption before the policy was issued.

The District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, Nagpur, also directed the insurer to pay 9 per cent annual interest on the claim amount from September 30, 2023, along with ₹10,000 for physical and mental harassment and ₹10,000 towards litigation costs.

The woman's husband had purchased the policy in April 2021 and died suddenly on January 26, 2023. The insurer rejected her claim, cancelled the policy and refunded ₹18,713 in premiums.

The company argued that the deceased had concealed chronic alcoholism, hypertension and diabetes, violating the principle of utmost good faith. The commission, however, noted that his May 20, 2021 medical examination form explicitly recorded that he consumed 90 ml of whisky twice a month and had done so for 15 years.

It also noted that the insurer's panel doctor had not recorded hypertension or diabetes during the pre-policy medical examination. Citing Supreme Court rulings treating hypertension and diabetes as lifestyle diseases, the commission held that the claim could not be rejected merely on the ground that these conditions were not disclosed.

(PTI)

Delhi HC seeks NTA response on NET retest



The Delhi High Court has sought responses from the Union Government and the National Testing Agency (NTA) on a plea challenging the decision to re-conduct the UGC-NET June 2026 English examination.

Justice Jasmeet Singh issued notice on a petition by candidate Parul Sheoran, who has sought quashing of the NTA's August 16 notice ordering the re-examination. The plea contends that the decision was arbitrary and procedurally unfair, and was taken without disclosing the material on which it was based.

The petitioner has sought processing of the results of the English examination already conducted. Alternatively, she has sought a refund of the examination fee paid for the original test and permission to appear in the re-conducted examination without paying an additional fee.

The court, on August 31, also directed the authorities to take a decision on refunding the examination fee and listed the matter for further hearing on October 6.

The NTA conducted UGC-NET June 2026 from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects. It later said it had received complaints about errors in the English, Commerce and Sociology papers and constituted a committee to examine them.

The committee reportedly found factual, typographical and translation errors, including misspelled scholars' names, garbled book titles, grammatical and punctuation mistakes, and repetition of several previously asked questions.

The English and Commerce papers are scheduled to be re-conducted on September 9, while Sociology will be held on September 10.

(PTI)

SC's Aravalli panel seeks extension for final report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court-appointed Aravalli High-Powered Committee (HPC) has asked the apex court to extend the deadline for submission of its final report by six months, saying it needs more time for a "comprehensive and defensible" assessment of the Aravalli range.

In its compliance report submitted on August 31, the committee has said it needs to bring together spatial, ecological, geological, hydrological, socio-economic, and stakeholder evidence before arriving at its conclusions regarding the Aravallis.

The committee, constituted through an order dated May 25, has been conducting



Aravalli range

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

an independent review of the Centre's report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis. The deadline for the panel's final report was August 31. "The committee



SC orders States to raise judicial retirement age

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In a bid to ensure that the attrition of the experienced judicial talent stops and access to justice does not remain a mere chimera, the Supreme Court has directed seven states to raise retirement age of judicial officers from 60 to 62 years.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said judicial officers in the seven states who have superannuated on or after March 31 this year shall be given an option to re-join the judicial office, if they have not already obtained subsequent employment.

"The states which have consented to the enhancement of age of the Judicial Officers,

namely, Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, are directed to amend the service rules and enhance the age of superannuation in the judicial service to 62 years, subject to the suitability assessment of the concerned Judicial Officer, on their attainment of the age of 60 years, by the High Court. Such amendments shall be carried out as early as possible, preferably within two months," the bench said.

"Pending amendment of the rules, no judicial officer in the aforesaid States who has attained the age of 60 years shall superannuate until he attains the age of 62 years, subject to an assessment of his suitability and performance by the High Court concerned," it said. The top court



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

directed Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Kerala, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Telangana, Tripura, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, NCT of Delhi, Jammu and Kashmir, and Puducherry to reconsider their decision on enhancing retirement age of judicial officers.

The apex court asked these states and Union Territories to

decide the issue within two weeks and submit a compliance report.

The top court said it has taken into consideration the fact that age differential may be a legitimate expectation in the superior judiciary.

"But, the crying need of the hour is to ensure that the attrition of the experienced judicial talent be arrested so that the gap between the sanctioned and the working strength in the judicial service is reduced, and access to justice does not remain a mere chimera due to unfilled posts.

"It is with this spirit that we request the High Courts and States to reconsider the issue with regard to enhancement of age of superannuation in the district judiciary, whose conditions of service are to

be governed by rules framed on their recommendation," the bench said.

The court said some high courts have wisely added relevant riders with regard to assessment of judicial work as a condition precedent so that "dead wood" can be removed, and only the competent officers of proven integrity may be permitted to continue in the cadre.

"This suggestion is most welcome as it would balance the preservation of experienced judicial officers while removing the clog of deadwood, blocking the entrance of young blood invigorating the system," the bench said.

Earlier, the bench had said that states cannot cite financial burden to oppose raising the retirement age of judicial officers.

Jharkhand DGP pick under SC scrutiny



Tadasha Mishra with Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren

FILE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The JMM government's appointment of Tadasha Mishra as Jharkhand DGP on December 30, 2025, a day before her retirement, was in violation of the Supreme Court's direction that an officer must have at least six months' residual service left at the time of assuming the office, the top court has been told.

Senior advocate and amicus curiae Raju Ramchandran, who is assisting a bench headed by Chief

Justice of India Surya Kant in hearing pleas related to alleged violation of the apex court's directions by various states on the procedures to be adopted in DGP appointments, has filed the note in pursuance of an order.

"The appointment of the current DGP (HoPF) one day prior to her retirement is clearly in complete violation of the principles laid down in the Prakash Singh-I, II, and III judgments and orders," Ramchandran said in the note submitted before the bench, which also comprised Justice Joymalya Bagchi.

CJI pushes BRICS to build stronger justice ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday highlighted the importance of the role of the judiciary in constructing coordinated bilateral cooperation and enhancing bilateral ties during the BRICS Chief Justices' Forum.

Speaking at the summit, he also proposed the building of a common platform for arbitration and mediation to tackle commercial disputes.

The Supreme Court on Friday held the BRICS Chief Justices' Forum here which was attended by chief justices, presidents of supreme courts and senior judicial leaders from BRICS member states and partner countries.

As part of the Forum, CJI Kant held a series of bilateral meetings with heads of judicial delegations on the opening day. The CJI met judicial leaders from Russia, China, Egypt, Indonesia, the UAE, Belarus, Kazakhstan, South Africa, Iran and Uzbekistan on the opening day of the three-day summit. The bilateral discussions took



CJI Surya Kant meets Chief Justice of the Supreme Court of the Russian Federation Igor Krasnov during a bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the BRICS Chief Justices' Forum, in New Delhi

PTI

place around the issues of MoUs for judicial cooperation to strengthen relations between countries, the importance of mediation and arbitration in resolving business and corporate disputes and creating a healthy environment for commercial activities between nations.

The discussions were also held on the requirement of efficient commercial courts to enhance trust of foreign investors, possibilities of

mutual recognition of judicial awards and decrees and use of state institutions like the National Judicial Academy, Bhopal, for professional exchange programmes.

Besides highlighting the importance of the role of the judiciary in constructing coordinated bilateral cooperation and enhancing bilateral ties, the CJI also proposed the building of a common platform for arbitration and mediation to tackle commer-

cial disputes.

CJI Kant held discussions with the judicial delegations on the exchange of best legal practices from different countries, the need for bilateral conferences on laws on contemporary issues, technology advancement integration for increasing the efficiency of the judiciary, especially through AI integration, and enhancing people-to-people ties through expeditious judicial processes.

Delhi hotel fire: Owner denied bail



Malviya Nagar hotel fire

PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has rejected the interim bail plea on medical grounds filed by the owner of a Malviya Nagar hotel where a fire claimed 23 lives, saying he was already receiving adequate specialised medical treatment in custody. Additional Sessions Judge Samar Vishal was hearing Lovkesh Bajaj's plea seeking four weeks interim bail, during which he said that the medical exigency cited by the accused had already been addressed through surgery at Delhi's Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital (RML).

In an order dated September 3, the court said, "The court is conscious of the seriousness of the applicant's medical condition and his entitlement to uninterrupted and appropriate medical care. However, the material presently available shows that such care is already being provided... interim bail for four weeks is neither medically indicated nor necessary at this stage".

Bajaj is named as an accused in the case over the fire at the five-storey 'Flourish Stay' B&B in Hauz Rani on June 3, in which 23 people were killed, while 24 others suffered grievous injuries.

SC orders probe into UP trial judge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Expressing displeasure over a trial court's repeated failure to submit the report sought by it, the Supreme Court has directed the registrar general of the Allahabad High Court to initiate a preliminary inquiry against the concerned judicial officer.

The apex court said the trial court had failed to submit the report before it on three occasions.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhara noted that in February 2020, the top court had directed the trial court to conclude within one year the proceedings in a suit seeking eviction of the respondents before it from a property.

It said in January this year, the apex court had observed that despite its February 2020 order, the trial was yet to be concluded.

The bench had summoned a report from the trial court which was not sent on February 12 or in March.

It said that in March this year, the registrar general of the high court was directed to apprise the trial court of



Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhara

SCJ.GOV.IN

sending the report immediately. "It was only thereafter that a report was sent by the trial court, and on May 12, 2026, we directed that the trial be completed within the next six months and the trial court shall submit its first status report on or before August 21, 2026," the bench noted in its August 24 order.

It said no report from the trial court was received by it.

"This is the third occasion where the concerned trial court has failed to submit a report as sought by this court," the bench said.

"In the aforesaid circumstances, the registrar general of the Allahabad High Court is directed to initiate a preliminary inquiry against the

concerned judicial officer and send a report to this court within 15 days," the bench said.

While posting the matter for September 21, the bench said that based on the preliminary report, it would consider initiation of a departmental inquiry against the concerned judicial officer. The apex court had passed the February 2020 order while hearing a petition challenging an April 2013 order of the Allahabad High Court. It had then noted that a suit filed in 2014 by the petitioners before it seeking eviction of the respondents from the property in question was pending.

Actor gets arrest shield over PM poster

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court has expressed "shock" over Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "obnoxious" depiction in a poster Bengali actor Sreelekha Mitra had displayed at a students' protest rally here in July, but granted her protection from arrest in FIRs lodged over the matter.

Several people protested on the streets of Kolkata on July 24 against the alleged NEET examination paper leak, demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, a day before the Union education minister stepped down in the wake of students' stir in Delhi and other parts of the country.

Mitra had joined the



Bengali actor Sreelekha Mitra

demonstration in the Esplanade area of central Kolkata and posed for a photograph while holding a poster. According to a com-

plaint lodged by the BJP, the poster displayed an offensive image of the Prime Minister. Several complaints had also been filed against her

across districts.

Hearing a petition by Mitra seeking quashing of the FIRs, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya said, "It shocks the conscience of the court, having seen the nature of the cartoon."

Terming the poster a "distasteful presentation," he said, "This ought not to have been posted by any prudent citizen of the country."

The high court judge sought to know from the actor's lawyer, Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya, why she had displayed such an "obnoxious cartoon" of the prime minister. To this, Mitra's counsel agreed that the poster was indeed distasteful, but it does not attract any criminal provision of the law.

Israel army released four more Lebanese civilians

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Israel has released four more Lebanese civilians who had been detained by its forces in southern Lebanon. Ship traffic remains low on the Strait of Hormuz days after the US and Iran exchanged attacks for the first time in a month. And fighting has intensified in Yemen between Iran-backed rebels and Government forces.

Israel on Thursday said it had agreed to release them after Lebanon provided assistance in searching for the bodies of Lebanese Jewish leaders who went missing in the 1980s during Lebanon's civil war.

Officials said the release comes as a result of US mediation and negotiations between Israel and Lebanon. Another round of talks is expected in Rome later this month. Ship traffic on the Strait of Hormuz remained low after the renewed US attacks on targets in Iran earlier this week and Iran's retaliatory attacks in the region, including firing at US



Gulf ally Kuwait on Thursday.

Fuel prices are again affected. Diesel hit a new record price in the US on Friday, soaring to an average of \$5.85 a gallon for the first time ever. The benchmark US crude price rose above \$91 a barrel with the new wave of uncertainty around traffic on the strait, which Iran continues to use as leverage after six months of war with the US. Fighting intensified overnight between Iran-backed Houthi rebels and Yemeni Government

forces along Yemen's west coast near an important supply route.

An official with the internationally recognised Government's health ministry told The Associated Press there were an unspecified number of casualties on both sides in the fighting in mountainous Taiz province. The official spoke on condition of anonymity because he wasn't authorised to speak with the media. A military official, who also spoke on condition of anonymity because he wasn't authorised to brief the media, confirmed casualties on both sides.

Jabal Nu'man overlooks a major supply route for Yemeni Government forces between Taiz province and Mokha, a port city heavily targeted by the Houthis in recent weeks. The Houthis' expansion of attacks in these areas appears to indicate an effort to gain full control of the Bab el-Mandeb strait, the southern gateway to the Red Sea, according to Moahmed Abdelrahman, a Taiz province spokesperson.

Dozens die in Nigeria oil theft attempt after inhaling toxic fumes



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Abuja

At least 37 people died in Nigeria's oil-producing Rivers state as they were trying to steal oil from a loading vessel, an advocacy group said on Friday.

The Youths and Environmental Advocacy Centre said the victims were simultaneously siphoning crude products into their boats from an "illegal tapping point" on Thursday.

It caused them to inhale toxic fumes at high pressure, leading to their deaths. Many are still missing, according to the report, quoting a

network of volunteers. The Nigerian police confirmed the incident on Friday but gave no death toll and said an investigation was underway.

"The Rivers State Police Command can confirm the deaths. The victims were allegedly attempting to steal crude oil," Blessing Agabe, Rivers State police spokesperson, said.

Oil theft is common in the Niger Delta region of Nigeria, Africa's biggest oil producer, where decades of oil exploration have led to high levels of poverty and environmental degradation.

Jordan faces Iranian attacks over military ties with US

SAM MCNEIL ■ Dubai

Jordan, a staunch US ally that hosts American forces in the Mideast, has paid a price for its relationship with Washington, which has made the kingdom's military bases a target of repeat Iranian strikes.

Hundreds of drone and missile attacks have added to other strains on Jordan that include a slumping economy and volatility in the neighbouring West Bank, where Israeli settlers have ramped up attacks on Palestinians.

Despite the risk of more strikes, Jordanian leaders

say they are committed to maintaining the relationship after decades of courting deeper security ties with American officials and offering to be a reliable partner with the West in a region rocked by conflict.

Analysts say the alliance offers Jordan a way to guard against Iran's attempts to destabilise its neighbours. King Abdullah II of Jordan seemed to acknowledge the need for such alliances last year, when he warned that destabilisation fuelled by the COVID-19 crisis, Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine and multiple Israeli military



campaigns in the Middle East could trigger chaos far beyond the region.

"We are living through wave after wave of disruption, without pause," he told European lawmakers. "There

is no telling where the boundaries of this battleground will end. That, my friends, is a threat to people everywhere." Jordan embraces Washington to weather stormy Middle East

The Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan is a puzzle-piece-shaped nation bordering Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Israel and the West Bank. More than 11 million Jordanians live between the Jordan River, the Red Sea and eastern deserts strewn with ruins.

Besides the threat from Iran, Jordan faces other challenges, such as an economy that has buckled under millions of refugees fleeing regional conflicts. Soaring energy prices and inflation have added to the burden as the tourism sector struggles to draw visitors to landscapes lionized in Hollywood

by Peter O'Toole, Harrison Ford and Matt Damon.

And next door, growing Israeli settler violence in the West Bank is deeply unsettling to Jordanians who fear instability could drive many of the 2.8 million Palestinians there to flee into the kingdom, said Sean Yom, a professor at Temple University and author of a 2025 book titled "Jordan: Politics in an Accidental Crucible." Since taking the reins from his father, King Hussein, in 1999, Abdullah has forged ever-stronger links between his capital, Amman, and Washington. (AP)

Sri Lanka arrests Namal Rajapaksa in Airbus deal corruption probe

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Sri Lanka's anti-corruption authorities have arrested opposition lawmaker Namal Rajapaksa, the son of former President Mahinda Rajapaksa, in connection with an investigation into a controversial Airbus aircraft deal worth about \$2.3 billion.

The Commission to Investigate Allegations of Bribery or Corruption (CIABOC) said Namal Rajapaksa, 40, appeared before investigators for questioning on Friday regarding the 2013 transaction. He was subsequently arrested and is expected to be produced before a magistrate.

The precise charges against the lawmaker were not immediately disclosed. His lawyer, Nishantha Dayananda, confirmed that Rajapaksa had been taken into custody. The investigation relates to allegations of corruption surrounding Sri Lanka's purchase of 10 Airbus aircraft. The transaction required Government approval and took place during Mahinda Rajapaksa's presidency, which lasted from 2005 to 2015.

Investigators are examining claims that money from the aircraft transaction was used to make illegal payments to influential Sri Lankan officials and politicians. Mahinda Rajapaksa was also questioned by CIABOC in May as



part of the investigation into alleged kickbacks connected to the deal. The Rajapaksa family has rejected allegations of wrongdoing, maintaining that the accusations are politically motivated.

Former Sri Lankan Airlines chief executive Kapila Chandrasena reportedly told investigators earlier this year that he had paid a substantial sum to Namal Rajapaksa. Court records indicate that Chandrasena initially alleged that about 60 million Sri Lankan rupees—around \$461,000 at the time—was paid in three instalments in 2013. He subsequently withdrew that account, saying his statement had been obtained under pressure.

Chandrasena was later found dead at a relative's residence in May, shortly before authorities were expected to arrest him again. The circumstances and cause of his death remain unresolved. The Airbus case stems from a wider international investigation into alleged bribery. Authorities in the United States, Britain and

France previously investigated the aircraft manufacturer and concluded that payments of roughly \$16 million had been agreed in relation to Sri Lanka. About \$1.7 million was allegedly channelled to Chandrasena before the wider scandal emerged.

Sri Lanka's government ultimately cancelled the aircraft agreement in 2016 after a change in administration. The controversy comes as SriLankan Airlines continues to face serious financial difficulties. The state-owned carrier has accumulated losses estimated at close to \$2 billion, while successive attempts to privatise or restructure the airline have struggled to produce a lasting solution.

The allegations against Namal Rajapaksa and other individuals remain subject to investigation and legal proceedings. Namal Rajapaksa issued a statement following his arrest and remand over the allegations, saying "he welcomes a fair and transparent investigation and will cooperate with the legal process."

He also questioned the timing of his remand until September 18, citing upcoming political rallies, while stressing that investigations must remain free from political interference and respect due process and the presumption of innocence. Political office is temporary. The rule of law must endure."

China arrests 52 Singaporeans over pyramid scheme activities

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Chinese authorities have arrested and detained 52 Singaporeans over their alleged involvement in pyramid scheme-related activities, in what could be the largest detention of the city-state's citizens abroad to date, officials said on Friday.

The 52 Singaporeans were detained as part of a wider law enforcement operation in southern China's Guangxi province targeting suspected pyramid scheme-related activities and offences, Singapore's Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MFA) and Singapore Police Force (SPF) said in a joint statement.

A pyramid scheme is a business model in which participants make money primarily by recruiting new members, rather than through the sale of legitimate products or services to consumers.

Chinese authorities are continuing their investigations, The Straits Times reported, adding that the SPF has contacted its Chinese counterparts to seek more information. Singapore's Embassy in Beijing and Consulate-General in Guangzhou have made three visits to all 52 detainees to check on their well-being and provide consular assistance.



Second Minister for Foreign Affairs Sim Ann

Sim, who is also Second Minister for Home Affairs, told local media that she had met the family members of most of the detainees. MFA and SPF did not provide further details about the case or the status of the investigations. It was also not immediately clear whether Chinese or other foreign nationals were detained in the operation.

"I would like to emphasise that the Singapore Government does not interfere in the judicial process and investigations of other countries, just as we expect foreign Governments to respect our laws and legal process," The Straits Times quoted Sim as saying.

Under Chinese law, people suspected of criminal activity can generally be detained for up to 37 days before prosecutors decide whether to approve their arrest. Investigations and evidence collection can subsequently take several months before prosecutors review a case for possible trial, according to The Straits Times.

The arrests come amid a nationwide crackdown in China against pyramid selling. Between 2021 and 2025, Chinese authorities investigated more than 200,000 cases involving pyramid schemes and direct-selling violations, according to the State Administration for Market Regulation. (PTI)

Report: US secret service policy gaps delayed threat updates

JESSE BEDAYN ■ Washington

The US Secret Service dealt with several drone-related incidents without adjusting its protection policies or documenting why it didn't, according to a Government report released on Thursday. That information may have helped illustrate the emerging threat of civilian drone use before one was used in the 2024

assassination attempt on then-candidate Donald Trump in Butler, Pennsylvania.

The report from the Government Accountability Office found delays and holes in how the Secret Service updates its policies regarding threats, and arrives after a few turbulent years for the agency charged with the president's protection.

The would-be assassin in Butler positioned himself on a roof left unsecured, nicking the president's ear with a bullet. Months later, a man with a rifle got surprisingly close to Trump at his West Palm Beach golf course. And in April, an armed man got beyond security barriers at the White House Correspondents' Dinner, where the president sat. The report found that between 2015 and 2025 the Secret Service dealt with 83 security incidents and that



they updated their protection policies in response to 25 of them. Among the incidents was a drone that made contact with President Barack Obama's motorcade in 2015 and another flown about 200 feet (60 metres) over a rally for then-presidential candidate Bernie Sanders.

Failing to document why the Secret Service decided not to change its policy is the concern, said Nathan Tranquilli, acting director of the Government Accountability Office, adding that the drone incidents were a "compelling example" of that. "Some of the missing information has been relevant to subsequent attacks," the report read. It cited the Butler incident, where the culprit flew a drone for 11 minutes over the crowd, which helped him position himself to get a clear shot at Trump. (AP)

US hits Cuba with new sanctions as island's crises multiply

DANICA COTO ■ Havana

The US Government on Thursday slapped new sanctions on Cuba in a fresh push to strangle the island's economy and deepen its multiple crises.

Among those hit with sanctions are Fidel Ernesto Castro, grandson of former President Raul Castro, and Cuba's Oil Industry Supply Import Company, known as Abapet. The company is responsible for importing special equipment and spare parts needed to sustain Cuba's crumbling power grid.

The sanctions aim to push Cuba's critical machinery offline and exacerbate its



energy crisis, said Brett Erickson, a sanctions expert and managing principal at Obsidian Risk Advisors, a consulting firm.

"The Trump administration seems to have no seriousness to accept any change from Cuba other than a toppling of regime. Marco is not going to let that go," he added. (AP)

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Rubi Kuswah, W/o Dharmender R/o- H.No 104/1 Adarsh Enclave, Krishna Ashram, Kharak Village, Chhatarpur, New Delhi - 110074, have changed my name to Rohima Khatun, that Rubi Kuswah and Rohima Khatun is one and the same person.

I, Brij Bhushan, S/o Shri Dharmender, R/o- H.No 104/1 Adarsh Enclave, Krishna Ashram, Kharak Village, Chhatarpur, New Delhi - 110074, have changed my name to Hussain, That Brij Bhushan And Hussain is one and the same person.

I, Bhawna Narula D/o Bhupinder Pal, W/o Mohit Narula, R/o K-76, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051 in my Pan Card my father's name wrongly written as Bhupindra Pal Arora . Actual name is Bhupinder Pal.

I, RUCHIKA BHATNAGAR, D/o Sh. Bharat Bhushan Bhatnagar, residing at D-100, First Floor, D-Block, Golf Residency, Sector 47, Noida - 201303, Uttar Pradesh, have voluntarily changed my name from Ruchika Bhatnagar to Sanaz Ashba and shall henceforth be known and identified as Sanaz Ashba for all legal, official, personal, financial and documentation purposes. I have changed my name only not my religion.

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Sunila Devi had acquired the rights of Plot No. H-11, measuring 200 sq. yds., vide Sale Deed dt. 27.08.2026 executed by Mrs. Meenu Kohar, duly regd. as Doc. No. 2026/22/11648 and Plot No. H-12, measuring 100 sq. yds., vide Sale Deed dt. 27.08.2026 executed by Mrs. Meenu Kohar, duly regd. as Doc. No. 2026/22/11649. Both Plots comprised in Khata No. 4047/2773/738, situated at Kailash Park, village Basai Darapur, New Delhi. Now Mrs. Sunila Devi is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with Hero FinCorp Limited.
OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance however or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 25/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi-110024

भारतीय प्रबंधन संस्थान रॉरी
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT RANCHI
(An Autonomous Institute of the Ministry of Education, Government of India)
Recruitment for Academic Associate
01 Post (EWS) at IIM Ranchi
IIM Ranchi, invites applications for the position of Academic Associate (01 post for EWS).
For further details regarding eligibility and application process please visit the website- <https://iimranchi.ac.in/>
Last date for receiving online application is 14.09.2026 till 5:00 P.M.

www.iimranchi.ac.in, 0651-2541100, 0651-2541101
Residential Area, Hazrat Nizamuddin Road, 110028, (Delhi)
Phone: 011-26101000, 011-2610101, 011-2610102

2 more bodies found in Cyprus ferry wreckage

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Istanbul

The remains of two more people have been recovered from the wreck of a passenger ferry that sank off the coast of Cyprus, the leader of the island's northern territory said Friday.

The findings bring the total confirmed deaths to 12, with 16 people still missing, Prime Minister Unal Ustel said in comments reported by the Cypriot newspaper Kibris.

The Filo Jet was carrying 267 passengers and crew when it capsized and sank after leaving Kyrenia, a port in northern Cyprus, for Tasucu, Turkey, on Sunday afternoon.

Two Turkish navy search and rescue vessels joined



the search, carrying submersible vessels able to reach the ferry wreckage some 550 metres (1,804 feet) below the surface.

Speaking to reporters at Kyrenia, known as Girne in Turkish, Ustel said the remains belonged to two women. The bodies of a

man and a woman were recovered earlier.

"Our search operations to reach our 16 missing people continue uninterruptedly on a 24/7 basis with the strong support of the Republic of Türkiye and the participation of all relevant units. They are carrying out

these operations under very difficult conditions," Ustel added. The search operation is being conducted about 7.5 kilometers off the northern Cypriot coast.

Survivors have said the ferry, a wide-bodied catamaran, began listing and taking on water after they heard a number of loud noises from below the decks, sparking panic on board.

They said people were trapped inside the passenger seating area as water gushed in and the ship lurched onto its side.

Eight crew and a director of the ferry's owner, Filo Denizcilik, are in custody. Five others, including Filo Denizcilik staff and port officials, are also under investigation.



PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Tender Cell Health Department

Tender Advertisement – New

Sr.No.	Particulars	Date
1	Tender Form Sale Period	05/09/2026 to 18/09/2026 up to 14.30 p.m.
2	Tender Form Receiving Period	05/09/2026 to 18/09/2026 up to 14.30 p.m.
3	Bid Submission End Date	18/09/2026 at 14.30 p.m.
4	Tender Opening Date	21/09/2026 at 15.00 p.m.

Tender NO.	Department Name	Name of Work	Tender Fees	B1/B2	Emd Amt.	Period of Work	For Tender Purpose Contact Person Name and Mobile No.
PMC/Health/05 2026-27	Health	Upgradation of Late. Sanjay Gandhi Hospital, Dopodi OT, ICU Unit & Male Ward along with Installation Testing, commissioning of equipments on turnkey basis period of 12 Months.	29679/-	B2	1%	12 Month	020-25501491

(Dr. Suryakant Deokar)
Asst. Medical Officer Of Health
Pune Municipal Corporation
जाहिरात क्र. 3/725, दिनांक : 4/09/2026

(Dr.Nina Borade)
Medical Officer
Pune Municipal Corporation

Guardians of frontiers: Chronicling the indomitable valor of Telugu military heroes



N UTTAM KUMAR REDDY

"A soldier's drop of blood shed on the borders...is a vermillion tilak on the forehead of Mother India!"

While we sleep peacefully in the warmth of our blankets at the midnight hour, a soldier stands guard without blinking an eye in the pitch-black darkness. Out there, on the freezing, oxygen-deprived peaks of Siachen where temperatures plunge to sub-zero levels, or across the scorching, soul-crushing dunes of distant deserts, he remains unyielding. Driven by the singular, pure hope that the children back home can laugh and play safely, he hugs his rifle tight to his chest, looking death straight in the eye every single moment.

The truth is, a soldier is not merely a human being draped in a uniform—he is a living, breathing monument of valor who has sacrificed his absolute everything for the motherland. For the sake of the nation, he leaves behind the unconditional love of a mother, the anxious prayers of a wife, the innocent laughter of his infants, and the protective embrace of family comfort. When festivals arrive and we light up our homes in celebration, that soldier stands completely alone amidst the deafening roar of bombs and a merciless rain of bullets, acting as an unbreakable fortress for the country.

Whether it is in the freezing heights of Kargil where enemy bullets pierce through the chest, or in the volatile valleys of Galwan where life fades into the eternal winds—even in their final, gasping breath, these warriors do not cry out for themselves.

The last word that escapes their parched lips is nothing but a triumphant roar of "Bharat Mata Ki Jai!" (Victory to Mother India!).

And when that mortal frame finally returns home, draped in the sacred folds of the tricolour flag, the scene is



heavy enough to break the sturdiest of hearts. To see a grieving mother wailing over the casket, a sister weeping inconsolably as she looks at the hands she once tied a Rakhi upon, and a young wife frozen in a lifetime of silent, shattering grief—there is no eye in this universe that can hold back its tears, and no soul that does not shatter.

We must never forget the profound truth that behind every single breath we freely inhale today lies the spilled blood of a soldier. For every single drop of crimson they have shed on the borders, and for every silent sacrifice they have endured, the entire nation bows its head in deep reverence, offering its tearful, eternal tributes.

The monumental contributions of India's Telugu-speaking regions to the Armed Forces remain a deeply proud yet insufficiently chronicled chapter in our national history. For generations, brave men and women from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have served the Army, Navy, and Air Force with unyielding courage, discipline, and exemplary professionalism.

From the decisive battlefields of the 1971 War and Operation Pawan to the freezing terrains of Siachen, the heights of Kargil, volatile counter-insurgency operations, and global United Nations peace-keeping missions, Telugu warriors have stood guard in the nation's most demanding theatres.

Leadership at the Apex of Command
This legacy of excellence spans from the frontline ranks

to the absolute highest echelons of military command.

General KV Krishna Rao, one of the finest military minds produced by Andhra Pradesh, served with great distinction as India's 11th Chief of the Army Staff. During the 1971 Indo-Pakistan War, the 8 Mountain Division under his strategic command successfully captured the Sylhet region, playing a pivotal role in the liberation of Bangladesh.

Similarly, Hyderabad-born Air Chief Marshal IH Latif, who headed the Indian Air Force from 1978 to 1981, epitomized the stellar tradition of visionary leadership associated with the Telugu soil.

The Echoes of Kargil and Galwan

The crucible of the 1999 Kargil War brought the exceptional valor of several Telugu servicemen into sharp national focus. Major Padmapani Acharya of the 2 Rajputana Rifles, a resident of Hyderabad, led his company against a heavily fortified enemy position under a relentless barrage of artillery and machine-gun fire. Despite being grievously wounded, he refused to back down, leading from the front until his final breath.

He was posthumously honored with the Maha Vir Chakra, India's second-highest wartime gallantry award.

During the same conflict, under Operation Vijay, several other brave sons of the soil laid down their lives for the motherland:

"Lance Naik Poloju Gopaiah Chary of Suryapet, serving with the 315 Field Regiment. "Lance Naik MY

Ramachander of Bolarum, serving with the 8 Madras Regiment.

"Sergeant PVN Ravi Prasad of the Indian Air Force, whose helicopter was struck during a high-stakes live mission in the Dras sector, earning him the Vayu Sena Medal posthumously.

This unbroken lineage of ultimate sacrifice continued into the modern era during the 2020 Galwan Valley clash. Colonel Bikkumalla Santosh Babu of Suryapet, the Commanding Officer of the 16 Bihar Regiment, led his men from the front under exceptionally hostile and brutal conditions. Despite suffering severe injuries, he fiercely resisted enemy attempts to push Indian troops back, making the ultimate sacrifice. His posthumous Maha Vir Chakra stands as a shining beacon of pride, permanently etched into the collective memory of Telangana and the entire nation.

Service Before Self: A Call to the Next Generation

These celebrated names represent just a fraction of the thousands of lesser-known soldiers, Junior Commissioned Officers, sailors, and airmen from the twin Telugu states who quietly guard our freedom.

As a former fighter pilot with the Indian Air Force, I understand firsthand that wearing the uniform is both a supreme privilege and a profound responsibility. Behind every sentinel guarding our frontiers stands a resilient family sharing that heavy burden in silent sacrifice. Honoring our Telugu military heroes must therefore transcend annual ceremonial homage.

Their extraordinary sagas of courage must enter our school classrooms, cultural institutions, and public consciousness—inspiring today's youth to embrace discipline, integrity, and the timeless ideal of service before self.

The author is Telangana's Minister for Irrigation and Civil Supplies and a former Indian Air Force fighter pilot

Women in Public Finance: Stories of gender in budgeting

RANI SINGH RAJPUT
■ New Delhi

Previous week, the famous publisher Routledge has come out with the articles by 22 women economists about their life stories. Chapter eight is about the life story of Indian economist Lekha S Chakraborty, Professor and Chair of the National Institute of Public Finance and Policy (NIPFP) in Delhi. The book is edited by Manal Fouad and Maja Bosnic.

"Born into a traditional Muslim family in India and abandoned by her father at the age of three, the author's journey has been one of resilience, determination, and breaking barriers. Despite early hardships, she pursued higher education with unwavering commitment, ultimately joining the Ministry of Finance Research Institute in New Delhi. Here, she had the privilege of contributing to one of India's pioneering initiatives in gender budgeting—a transformative project aimed at integrating gender perspectives into public financial management to promote equality and social justice, in a country where gender discrimination starts even before birth.

"My mum was abandoned by my dad when I was three years old, just as my younger brother was born. It was while she was in the advanced stage of this pregnancy that my father's decision of 'Talaq' (divorce) was delivered to her by post in a simple inland letter. From that moment, the way she managed to raise her two children alone is a story of sadness and profound grit, only a few can realise," starts the eighth chapter, titled 'Gender Budgeting: That fire in my belly', written by Lekha S Chakraborty.

Narrating the hardships of life of a daughter of separated parents to studying Economics from Kerala and reaching into the subject—gender budgeting—the writer says: Years later, when I began pioneering gender budgeting work in India, every meeting on the subject stirred deep turmoil



Lekha S Chakraborty

within me, because every time a gender issue was raised, I felt they were speaking about my mother. Every issue was a personal blow that left me vulnerable within. It has taken a lot of time and work not to take everything personally, to discuss matters related to gender boldly, to move confidently in the policymaking sphere and drive changes in public policies.

In every moment of success, I stood detached to seize that moment, as this abandonment haunts me most in those moments of success; and like a dart, success pierces me with the experiences I have undergone as a child, and the distance I travelled from a traditional Muslim family raised by a single mother to who I am now. My story is about the power of serendipity, though I have a fire in my belly to "become someone". I do not know how to articulate how and from where that fire came from. I leave it to you to understand, said Lekha.

She writes, India started initiating gender budgeting in early 2000 and in 2004 adopted gender budgeting by allotting three per cent of GDP in each sector. When India's Union Budget 2001-02 was unveiled, the UN commissioned me to analyse it through a gender lens—as a foundational study for advocacy. During Parliament's post-presentation recess, I

crafted the "2001 Gender Budgeting Macro Scan Report", disseminating it to Parliamentary Standing Committees to spark informed debates in "Vote on Account" sessions. I presented my study findings to the Rajya Sabha's women Parliamentarians, chaired by the Deputy Speaker, igniting momentum for gender budgeting. Yet formal institutionalisation arrived only in 2004 via the Ministry of Finance.

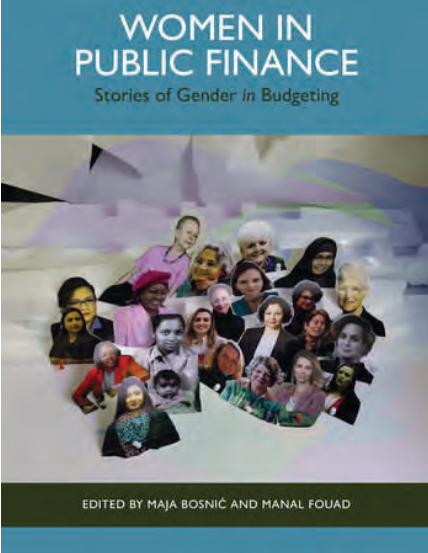
"With multilateral organisations and UN entities, gender budgeting gained momentum. A pivotal turning point was the UN's inaugural regional meeting on gender budgeting in Kathmandu, in 2001. There, the UN commissioned a South Asia-wide study, mirroring the methodology I had pioneered. I was tasked by the UN to do my first international assignment: moving to Colombo to lead it, collaborating with Sri Lanka's Ministry of Finance, Finance Commission, Ministry of Women, and sectoral ministries. The framework, far from sector-agnostic, involved crafting analytical matrices and institutional mechanisms with budget officials.

Translated into vernacular languages, the research was disseminated provincially for subnational gender budgeting. In the 2002 Budget Speech, Sri Lanka announced its national and subnational rollout—predating India's

institutionalisation.

"In 2004, India institutionalised gender budgeting. India also rolled out the adoption of fiscal rules capping the fiscal deficit at 3 per cent of GDP annually. My expertise in macroeconomics and human development earned recognition; the Ministry of Finance invited me as a member of the 2003 "Classification of Budgetary Transactions Committee," tasked with institutionalising a template grounded in gender budgeting. Our recommendations led to the Budget Speech announcing that India would launch gender budgeting from 2005-06, enforced rigorously via Budget Call Circulars.

"Concurrently, the Government of India summoned representatives from 29 states to Delhi for perspectives and training on state-level implementation. Retaining our methodology, I drafted the Methodology Manual and led the sessions. I was thrilled by the earnest deliberations across states—our framework, built from a clean slate, now cascading into tangible policy impacts. It marked a validation, and gender budgeting was hailed as fiscal innovation," writes Lekha S. Chakraborty, dedicating the chapter to her mother Salma, a Government nurse whose upbringing taught the need for gender budgeting for the welfare of women and children.



SAIL posts strong sales and production in August 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



and faster market servicing.

Rail supplies to Indian Railways increased 5 per cent year-on-year to 1.23 lakh tonnes from 1.18 lakh tonnes. Supplies of long rails reached a record 1.12 lakh tonnes, registering 11 per cent growth.

SAIL also strengthened its financial position by reducing borrowings by ₹870 crore from the March 31, 2026 level.

During April-August 2026, cumulative sales stood at 7.71 MT, registering 5.6 per cent growth over the corresponding period last year despite global volatility. Finished and processed steel segments continued to witness healthy movement, supported by an improved product mix, stronger regional outreach and firm domestic demand.

AIDA, IIT Delhi launch white paper on India's Flex-Fuel mobility roadmap beyond E20

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Distillers' Association (AIDA) and IIT Delhi have unveiled a landmark white paper outlining a roadmap for scaling Flex-Fuel Vehicles (FFVs) as India moves towards the next phase of its ethanol and clean mobility journey beyond E20.

The white paper, titled "Flex-Fuel Vehicles: Enabling Energy Security and Sustainable Mobility in India," was launched at the AIDA Green Energy Seminar 2026, which brought together policymakers, automotive leaders, ethanol producers, fuel companies, researchers and technology experts.

The study examines key elements required for large-scale FFV adoption, including vehicle technology, fuel pricing, infrastructure readiness, sustainable feedstock, consumer acceptance, financing and market development. It presents a prioritised ten-



point policy roadmap covering immediate and long-term measures to build a commercially viable flex-fuel ecosystem.

The paper argues that FFVs can strengthen energy security, reduce crude oil dependence, expand consumer fuel choice and support cleaner mobility while leveraging India's growing domestic ethanol production capacity.

Alongside the IIT Delhi publication, CRID India launched its white paper, "Towards a Sustainable Bioenergy Future for India: Feedstock Security, Land-Water Balance and The Path Beyond E20."

The study examines

how India can expand ethanol production while balancing food security, agricultural sustainability, land use and water resources. It also provides an evidence-based assessment of the "food versus fuel" debate.

According to the study, ethanol-attributable land in 2023-24 was approximately 3.46 million hectares, or around 1.58 per cent of India's gross cropped area.

Together, the two white papers present a holistic vision for India's post-E20 future, addressing sustainable ethanol production on the supply side and the mobility pathway through Flex-F

BMC Bank crosses ₹4,000 crore business milestone

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai



Bombay Mercantile Co-operative Bank Ltd recorded significant growth across key financial and business parameters during FY 2025-26, reaffirming its focus on sustainable growth, financial strength and improved customer service.

Addressing shareholders at the Bank's 89th Annual General Meeting held at Haj House, Mumbai, on September 4, Chairman Zeeshan Mehdi said the Bank's total business crossed the ₹4,000 crore milestone, rising nearly 6 per cent from ₹3,925 crore to ₹4,165 crore.

Despite global turbulence and economic uncertainties, the Bank achieved an operating profit of ₹66 crore, registering a growth of over 65 per cent. Net profit also increased significantly from ₹2.38 crore to ₹14.37 crore. "The results reflect the collective efforts of our Board, Management and Employees, along with the continued trust and support of our Shareholders and Customers," Mehdi said.

Speaking to the media, Interim Managing Director Ishraq Ali Khan said deposits grew 6.42 per cent to ₹2,700 crore, while advances increased 5.54 per cent to ₹1,465 crore. The Bank also strengthened its asset quality, with Gross NPA declining 15 per cent from ₹84 crore to ₹71 crore. Gross NPA and Net NPA ratios stood at 4.84 per cent and 1.44 per cent, respectively, while CRAR improved to 13.70 per cent, above the regulatory requirement.

The Bank's foreign exchange business registered a robust 42 per cent growth, reaching ₹12,896 crore. Khan said the improvement in profitability and asset quality resulted from focused recovery efforts, prudent lending, better financial management and greater operational efficiency.

Karur Vysya Bank opens new branch in Udyog Vihar



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Karur Vysya Bank has opened a new branch in Udyog Vihar, Sector 18, Gurugram, to strengthen and expand its customer services.

The branch was inaugurated on August 31, 2026, in the presence of dignitaries including Mukti Suhag, Col Vivaswan Suhag of Lt Atul Katarya School, and Anshu Arora of Amity International School. The bank said the new branch will offer fast and convenient banking services to residents, business owners, entrepreneurs, corporates and industrialists in the area, with a focus on accessible and customer-centric financial services.

Janmashtami celebrated at Akshardham temple in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Purana. They explained that surrender to God is not merely an emotional expression but a spiritual practice aimed at making one's life God-centric.

Children and youths presented devotional and cul-



tural performances, including a dance-drama depicting the divine birth and character of Shri Krishna. Devotional music, prayers and spiritual discourses created an atmosphere of jubilation at the

temple. Janmashtami was also celebrated in Paris under the auspices of BAPS (Akshardham), ahead of the consecration ceremony of France's first traditional Hindu temple on September 6.

India's book publishing market projected to reach ₹2 lakh crore by 2030-31

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's book publishing market is projected to reach ₹2 lakh crore by 2030-31, according to the India Book Market Report 2026-2030, released in New Delhi by the Federation of Indian Publishers (FIP) in partnership with NielsenIQ BookData.

The report examines the growth prospects of India's print, digital, educational and scholarly publishing sectors. It also focuses on Indian-language publishing, education,



research, artificial intelligence, copyright, creator rights and government policy. The report describes India as a market with significant

potential to become a globally important knowledge and publishing hub.

It highlights opportunities for investment and inno-

vation while stressing the need for sustainable growth, stronger copyright protection and responsible adoption of new technologies.

Vikrant Mathur, Executive Director of NielsenIQ BookData, India & GCC, said the report provides a clearer understanding of the scale, structure and evolution of India's publishing industry. He said the study combines market data and industry expertise to provide insights that can assist businesses, policymakers and other stakeholders.

BRIEFLY

Asiad-bound shooters to undergo preparatory camps in Delhi, Bhopal



The Asian Games-bound Indian shooters will undergo preparatory camps at facilities in Delhi and Bhopal this month as they look to fine-tune their skills for peak performance at the quadrennial showpiece beginning September 19 in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.

The camps have been divided between the MP State Shooting Academy in Bhopal and the Karni Singh Range in the national capital.

As per the schedule, the selected Asian Games pistol and rifle shooters will train in Bhopal from September 5 to 14.

The skeet camp commenced at the Karni Singh Range on Friday, while the camp for trap shooters will be held from September 10 to 18 at the same venue. National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) High Performance Director Pierre Beauchamp said the focus of the camps would be on mental conditioning and technical refinement. (PTI)

Gukesh, Sindarov face off in November for world crown



Javokhir Sindarov knows the ultimate challenge awaits him later this year when he takes on defending champion D Gukesh for the world crown, but the Uzbek chess prodigy says his preparations for the showdown will begin only after this month's Chess Olympiad.

Sindarov will face Gukesh in a battle for the world crown between two 20-year-olds in Geneva over 14 classical games from November 24 to December 12.

However, the Uzbek is currently keeping his focus firmly on the tournaments immediately ahead, rather than anticipating the much-anticipated title clash to dominate his thoughts. "Right now, I'm focusing on my next events – the Global Chess League and the Olympiad. After those, I will start preparing for the World Championship match," Sindarov, who will represent Fyers American Gambits in the fourth edition of GCL, said. (PTI)

Carlсен urges chess to look beyond him

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Chess' undisputed king Magnus Carlsen enjoys being part of the game's evolution and experimentation with new formats, but feels that his time at the top is "limited" and said organisers should not shape the future of chess around his preferences. The five-time world champion, who has opted out of the classical World Championship cycle, will return to action in the fourth season of the Global Chess League (GCL).

"Look, I think there are a lot of positives in the chess world these days," Carlsen, who holds the highest rating in chess history at 2882 and continues to lead the FIDE rankings as the world's No. 1 player, said during an interaction here.

Asked whether the emergence of new fans and formats over the last five to six years was now a motivating factor for him, Carlsen said; "Over the last 5-6 years, there have been a lot of new chess fans all around the world, and we're still trying to find the right formats to present the game.

"For me, it's interesting to be part of those innovations, but it's not necessarily an over-

arching goal," added Carlsen, who will represent Alpine APL Pipers in GCL. The Norwegian superstar further said his motivation fluctuates from tournament to tournament, but stressed that organisers should not build their plans around him given the limited time he has left as an active player.

"I'm motivated for tournaments —sometimes more than other times, which is plain to see in how I approach them.

"But it kind of is what it is now. What's more important for the future of chess is that you (organisers) shouldn't necessarily try things because of what I want to do or what motivates me. There's a pretty limited time frame in terms of when I'm going to be around

"I'M MOTIVATED FOR TOURNAMENTS — SOMETIMES MORE THAN OTHER TIMES, WHICH IS PLAIN TO SEE IN HOW I APPROACH THEM"



as well." But the 35-year-old made it clear that he remains eager to compete and is particularly looking forward to the GCL, whose rapid format suits him.

"For now, I like to play and I'm looking forward to competing here. It's a similar time format to what I was successful in recently."

Carlsen has been a central figure in the modernisation of chess, but his own competitive priorities have increasingly shifted towards shorter formats and selected events after he chose not to defend his world title in the classical format. He further spoke on his mixed record in team competitions. "Team events have been a bit up and down for me over the years, though it's been better recently. In the last couple of Olympiads, I performed decently even if team results fluctuated. Winning the European Club Cup in '23 was honestly one of the highlights of my career," he said.

Vishesh wins maiden title at Telangana Golconda Masters



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Local favourite Vishesh Sharma showed steely resolve to emerge triumphant following a dramatic final round to secure his maiden professional title at the ₹one crore Telangana Golconda Masters here on Friday.

The 19-year-old closed with a one-under 69 to finish at 21-under 259, one stroke ahead of Noida's Amardeep Malik at Hyderabad Golf Association.

Vishesh (60-66-64-69), playing his second season on the DP World PGTI, collected ₹15 lakh. The victory lifted him from 25th to 14th on the 2026 Order of Merit, taking his season earnings to ₹30,93,550, and secured his place in the

DP World India Championship.

Malik (61-65-68-66) mounted a strong challenge with a closing four-under 66 but finished runner-up at 20-under 260. His eventful round contained an eagle on the par-five sixth, six birdies, two bogeys and a double bogey.

The 41-year-old earned ₹10 lakh and moved from 22nd to 19th on the Order of Merit, with season earnings of ₹27,75,748. Chandigarh's Akshay Sharma (69-69-63-60) matched the course record with the lowest round of the day, a 10-under 60. His round featured an eagle, 10 birdies and two bogeys, including four successive birdies from the third through the sixth. He climbed into a share of third at 19-under 261.

SAI's 'container simulator' prepares athletes for unusual Asian Games stay

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Patiala

The beds are a little over six feet long, the walls are close, and there is little room for anything beyond the essentials.

For some of India's athletes, however, spending a night inside a shipping container at the Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports (NSNIS) here is less about discomfort and more about preparation for an unusual living arrangement awaiting them in Japan at the Asian Games.



With the Aichi-Nagoya Games beginning September 19 and no conventional athletes' village this time, Sports Authority of India (SAI) has set up makeshift container rooms at its centres in Patiala and Bengaluru to give its athletes a taste of what they can expect in Japan. The idea is to make the unfamiliar familiar.

Athletes are taking turns to spend a night inside the container, waking up the next morning and following their usual routine

before heading to training. By the time they reach Japan, the hope is that their accommodation will no longer be a distraction. "Two years ago, when it was established that the accommodation at the Asian Games will be in a unique style — containers, cruise etc. — and not a village, at that time the Sports

Minister's vision was that the players must be acclimatised in a similar way, like a simulator," Deputy Director General, SAI, Vineet Kumar said.

For athletes, accustomed to sprawling rooms and dedicated spaces for their equipment, the compact surroundings can take some getting used to. (PTI)

Sheetal leads charge as Ahmedabad hosts international para archery event



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Trailblazer Sheetal Devi will be the centre of attention when India's finest para archers take aim in country's first international para archery event beginning in Ahmedabad on Saturday. The third stage of the 2026 Hyundai World Archery Para Series that will conclude on Wednesday brings 109 archers from 19 countries to India for a competition that also serves as an important build-up to the Aichi-Nagoya 2026 Asian Para Games.

At the forefront of the home challenge is Sheetal, the world number one in compound women and the reigning world champion, who will be competing in front of the home crowd for the first time in an international event. The

19-year-old has already established herself as one of the sport's biggest names.

Born without arms, Sheetal uses her right foot and shoulder to draw the bow and a specialised release aid held in her mouth to shoot.

At the Gwangju 2025 World Archery Para Championships, she became the first woman without arms to win a para archery world title, defeating defending champion and Paralympic champion Ozgur Cure Girdi of Türkiye 146-143 in the compound women's final. That world title added to a glittering record that already included a mixed team bronze at the Paris 2024 Paralympics alongside Rakesh Kumar — making her India's youngest Paralympic medallist at 17 — and two gold medals at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games.

Kidambi ousted in China Masters quarterfinals



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Shezhen (China)

Kidambi Srikanth's run at the China Masters Super 750 came to an end in the quarterfinals in Shezhen as the former world Number 1 was outplayed by Hong Kong's Lee Cheuk Yiu. The 33-year-old Indian, who had shown flashes of his vintage best while finishing runner-up at the US Open Super 300 earlier this year, went down 16-21, 16-21 to the 25th-ranked Lee Cheuk.

Srikanth looked sharp in the previous round, dispatching Victor Lai of Canada in the Round of 16. But against Cheuk, the Indian found himself chasing the game for long stretches, particularly after surrendering the momentum midway.

A 30-game win streak for US on the line at the FIBA women's World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

The FIBA women's World Cup begins with the US in search of a fifth consecutive championship. The Americans have won 30 straight games in the tournament, dating to a loss to Russia in the 2006 semifinals. They'll have a young group of players trying to extend that run led by Caitlin Clark, Angel Reese and Paige Bueckers, who are making their debuts in the event.



It's not all youth for the US as gold medal collector Breanna Stewart, who has already won three Olympic and three World Cup championships leads the squad. France will be the main competitor for the Americans, having lost by only one point

in the 2024 Paris Olympics gold medal game. The French team is hungry to avenge that loss. Other teams that could be a threat to end the US streak include Spain, Belgium and China. The Chinese team lost to the Americans in the 2022 World Cup final.

The 16 teams were put into

four groups and each will have a round-robin stage. The second- and third-place teams in each group will advance to a qualification round while the winner of the pool will advance to the quarterfinals. The four winners of qualification rounds will then advance to the quarterfinals as well.

DAILY SUDOKU

9								1
2	4		5				7	3
		7		6	4			
	7		4	2	6			
4								8
			3	8	7		6	
			8	9		2		
7	9				3		1	5
1								6

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (4.9.26)

5	3	2	7	6	9	4	8	1
4	1	8	2	3	5	6	9	7
6	7	9	4	8	1	3	2	5
9	6	1	3	7	2	8	5	4
7	2	5	1	4	8	9	3	6
8	4	3	9	5	6	1	7	2
3	8	6	5	2	4	7	1	9
1	5	4	8	9	7	2	6	3
2	9	7	6	1	3	5	4	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

SATURDAY | SEPTEMBER 5, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8	
			9									
10								11				
								12				
13		14								15		16
17								18				
								19				
20	21									22		23
24								25				
								26				
27										28		
								29				
30										31		

ACROSS

1 A cost adjustment in opera (5)
6 At first, initially, hers may be new (5)
9 Fit out casually and formally (7)
10 Show willingness to be tender (5)
11 Strangely like the third man out? (5)
12 It's instrumental in Mozartian magic (5)
13 Writers who need a crib! (7)
15 The boys in the automobile club (3)
17 Soft to eat, gardeners may buy it (4)
18 The airman may find her disturbing (6)
19 When a child gets them, it's symbolic (5)
20 Hit a fair way (6)
22 On which to advertise toothpaste? (4)

DOWN

2 Whence the staff can get away for refreshment (6)
3 Belief in direct negotiation (6)
4 We all have a perfect right to it (3)
5 The documents one wishes (5)
6 Floats around a lot, doesn't it? (7)
7 Dyer's place? (4)
8 In the pink, is able to climb a ladder (6)
12 For a criminal, look in a low area (5)
13 In informal use, they often get chipped (5)
14 Fanatical weaver of braid (5)
15 A sign where the terminus terminates (5)

ACROSS

9 D is close
10 Son (rev)
11 Inu-red
12 Shut up
13 Smashed
14 m(Oral)e
15 Blasted off
17 Man-Ifold
18 S-Carl-et
19 Bank
21 Off-end
24 Stopping at

DOWN

1 High places
2 S-cat
3 Comp-L-ete
4 Versio-N
5 In the making
6 Finding out
7 Pu-t-o-ff
8 Be-fail-en
10 Staff
16 S-tr-join

ACROSS

20 A-pace
22 Fri-ends
23 Inside story
25 Passed over
26 Gather-sway
28 T-R-apping
31 A-dher-ent
32 Honest-Y
34 Hang-up
35 C-love
39 Pads



Asia Cup: India favourites against Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Having already made the semi-finals, a far superior India will be expected to step up the intensity against traditional foes Pakistan in their final league game of the Women's Asia Cup here on Saturday.

Men or women, routinely scheduled Indo-Pak fixtures in multi-team events have not lived up to the off-field hype for a while now. Nothing different is expected when the two teams meet at the Dubai with overwhelming title favourites India expected to steamroll Pakistan. That is not to say that India don't have work to do in the shortest format, having made premature exits in past two World Cups.

They need to develop a pool of power-hitters and fast bowlers to challenge the hegemony of Australia.

However, at the Asia level, no side comes close to India's level. The Indians had somehow finished runners-up to Sri Lanka in



the previous edition. Pakistan, on the other hand, have won their opening game against Thailand and remain in contention for the last-four stage.

Ahead of the game, both India openers Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma looked at the top of their game. Mandhana broke a battery of records against Hong Kong en route a memorable hundred to fire out a warning for the other teams. The pitches here have not been the easiest to bat on.

The batters usually take about 10 balls or so to assess the pace of the surface and accordingly plan their innings.

This is exactly what Mandhana and Shafali did on Thursday night. The likes of Pratika Rawal, Richa Ghosh and skipper Harmanpreet Kaur will look to spend more time in the middle, having not been able to convert starts. Pressure is mounting on new number three Rawal,

who has not been able to meet the demands of the T20 game, having found plenty of success in the ODI format.

The addition of Nandani Sharma in the pace attack is a step in the right direction as she is delivering on her promise while opening the bowling alongside spearhead Kranti Gaud. Pakistan, on the other hand, need drastic improvement in their batting to competing with India.

The shortcomings in the batting department have let the team down for a number of years.

Even in their last game against Thailand, Pakistan found themselves under pressure in the power-play with the loss of three wickets. However, they managed to defend a lowly 119 against a less-established side. The team over-relies on opener Muneeba Ali and bowling all-rounder Fatima Sana who is also the captain of the side.



I never imagined: Mandhana on surpassing Mithali's feat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Smriti Mandhana had to pinch herself after surpassing Mithali Raj to become the leading run-getter in Women's Internationals as she "never imagined" to go past the legendary Indian batter.

Mandhana played a major chunk of her career under Mithali's captaincy and the former India captain was also her role model growing up.

History was created at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium on Thursday as the Indian vice-captain went past Mithali Raj's tally of 10,868 International runs. Mandhana now has 10,880 across the three formats.

"Yeah, I mean, till I was batting, I didn't know what record it was because I didn't know the exact runs or all of that. But yeah, looking back, one of a very good day for Indian cricket, I would say. Of course, Mithali-di has been such a legend and a role model, and we've all grown up watching her bat," said Mandhana.

India, Japan to play men's T20I ahead of Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Indian men's cricket team will take on Japan in their first-ever T20 International on September 22, marking the launch of celebrations for the 75th anniversary of India-Japan diplomatic relations.

The match, to be played in Sano in Japan, will offer the Indian team valuable game time to fine-tune combinations and build momentum ahead of the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya from September 19 to October 4.

"The Japan Cricket Association (JCA) and the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) are delighted to announce that the men's teams from each nation will play a T20 International match to launch the celebrations of the 75th anniversary of India-Japan Diplomatic Relations," said BCCI in a statement.

The teams will compete for the Suzuki Cup at the Sano



International Cricket Ground in Tochigi Prefecture, Japan.

"The match will be the first step of 'Sport 75', an initiative that stems from an agreement reached during a summit between Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and aims to promote human exchanges

and cooperation between India and Japan in the field of sports, taking note of India's ambition to host the Olympic and Paralympic Games in 2036," the statement added.

The Indian team will be led by Shreyas Iyer, with vice-captain Tilak Varma, Sanju Samson and teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi

among the key names in the squad. India are the defending Asian Games champions after claiming gold at the previous edition in Hangzhou, China, where their final against Afghanistan was washed out by rain and they were awarded the title on the basis of their higher T20I seeding.

We are always one step ahead of Pakistan: Deepti



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Senior all-rounder Deepti Sharma on Friday said that India have always been one step ahead of Pakistan in their recent meetings and would look to continue just like that when they face each other in the Women's Asia Cup here on Saturday.

India, who have already made it to the semifinals with one game in hand, will start as favourites against Pakistan in their final league game. The Harmanpreet Kaur-led team is currently on top of Group A with two dominating wins — against Thailand

and Hong Kong. "Look, there is no advantage as such. The only thing is that whatever we have won against them (Pakistan), whether it is the Asia Cup or any other matches, we are always one step ahead of them. And that's it," Deepti said.

"The whole team is performing well. If you look at the bowling unit or the batting unit, I think both things are balanced. The one who has a good day, she tries to do better and take the game further. And those around her, they try to stay positive things so that they step in more in their game."

BCCI hands Bengal spinner Rohit 2-year ban for age fraud



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

The BCCI has imposed a two-year ban on Bengal leg-spinner Rohit Yadav for allegedly misrepresenting his age, weeks after he was selected in India's Under-19 squad for the upcoming series against Australia. Rohit, who is originally from Uttar Pradesh, had represented India during the Under-19 team's tour of Sri Lanka in July, taking six wickets and helping the side win the final Test. "He has been banned for two years," said a BCCI source.

He was also part of India's U-19 home one-dayers and multi-day games against the touring Australia U-19 side in Rajkot and Ahmedabad, slated later this month.

The age discrepancy came to light when his documents were scrutinised in Sri Lanka. Rohit has three birth certificates carrying different years of birth — 2007, 2009 and 2010 — making him ineligible to play in age-group cricket.

'To play against SA at SuperSport Park in WC would be dream ending'



BHARAT SHARMA
New Delhi

At the ripe old age of 41, Roelof van der Merwe is seeking to end his eventful journey in international cricket at the SuperSport Park in Centurion, his home ground in South Africa before he shifted his allegiance to the Netherlands in 2015. Defeating the men from his country of birth in next year's ODI World Cup would only add to the drama of his fairy tale ending in international cricket, Roelof visualises in his virtual interaction.

"We still have a few hurdles (for qualification) to jump over and hoops to jump through to get into the World Cup. We've got a good team and we've got a good set-up to actually achieve that.

"It would be an unbelievable tournament for me. If that is to be my last World Cup, to finish it maybe at Supersport Park. Maybe even against South Africa, that would be a dream ending," said Roelof, one of the few cricketers who have represented two teams in international cricket. Provided they qualify, the Netherlands would back themselves to get the better of South Africa for the third time in an ICC event. Roelof is currently in the middle of a significant campaign in the inaugural European T20 Premier League (ETPL), Europe's first multi-country franchise T20 league.

Hesson distances himself from decision to drop senior players on England tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi

Pakistan's interim red-ball head coach Mike Hesson on Friday distanced himself from the decision to drop senior players Mohammad Rizwan, Salman Agha and Imam-ul-Haq from the Test squad following a disastrous tour of England, where Pakistan have lost the opening two matches by heavy margins.

Pakistan suffered an innings defeat in the first Test before going down by 194 runs in the second, prompting the axing of seven players and the sacking of head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed.



Hesson, who had been serving as Pakistan's white-ball head coach, was subsequently handed red-ball reins for third and final Test in Birmingham, starting September 9. "Look when they (PCB) told

me if I could manage the side for the final Test, these three players (Rizwan, Agha and Imam) were already released from the squad and (were) on their way home. So, I really don't know what happened there," Hesson said. Hesson said that he was involved in the release of the rest of the players and the inclusion of some new players.

"We already had a white-ball camp in Lahore and I had just returned from Japan where the Asian Games are taking place, when I was asked if I could manage the red-ball squad," he added.

Satwik-Chirag enter China Masters semis; Srikanth ousted

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Shezhen (China)

India's ace men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty battled through a gruelling three-game contest against Denmark's Kim Astrup and Anders Skaarup Rasmussen to storm into the semifinals of the China Masters Super 750 on Friday, even as veteran Kidambi Srikanth's campaign ended in the men's singles quarterfinals.

The fourth-seeded Indians prevailed 21-13, 16-21, 21-18 in a 70-minute battle to keep their impressive run going after a silver-medal finish at the Thailand Open Super 500 and a top-podium spot at the Singapore Open Super 750 in May.

Satwik and Chirag came out firing, racing to a 5-1 lead and dictating the rallies with a flurry of winners.



They maintained their attacking rhythm to open up a seven-point cushion at 16-9 before comfortably pocketing the opening game.

The Danes, however, upped the intensity in the second game, matching the Indian duo shot for shot. Locked at 15-15, Astrup and

Rasmussen produced a decisive burst of six points across two runs to force a decider. The third game lived up to its billing, with neither pair willing to surrender an inch.

At 17-17, the contest hung in the balance, but Satwik and Chirag dug deep when it mattered most, stringing

together three crucial points to move to 20-17. After conceding one, the Indians held their nerve to seal the match and book their place in the last four. Srikanth's run came to an end in the quarterfinals as the former world Number 1 was outplayed in straight games by Hong Kong's Lee Cheuk Yiu.

Aqib Javed likely to be removed from Pakistan selection committee as PCB pushes clean-up

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi

Pakistan Cricket Board is likely to remove former Test cricketer and senior selector Aqib Javed from the national selection committee as part of wider "clean-up" operation being carried out behind scenes, a source close to board said.

The development comes days after senior players Mohammad Rizwan, Imam-ul-Haq and Salman Ali Agha were sent back from England, a decision that has triggered speculation about the selection policy and team management. "Aqib is also likely to be told to focus on his role as Director Development at the Lahore High



Performance Centre," the source said.

He claimed that sending back Rizwan, Imam and Salman was part of the PCB's broader plan, with the first two being dropped not

only for poor form but also over their behaviour in the dressing room. "The rest of the players sent back were done so on the recommendation of interim red-ball head coach Mike Hesson, who wanted to try out some players he had worked with in the white-ball camp," the source said.

The source claimed that PCB chairman Mohsin Naqvi was keen on a "clean-up" and that the selection committee could be the next area of change. "Aqib, who is considered the blue-eyed boy of the chairman, is also likely to be told to just focus on his role as Director Development at the Lahore High Performance Centre," he said.

Cafu: Indian team will benefit from international friendly against Brazil



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Navi Mumbai

Former Brazil captain Cafu on Friday said the Indian team will learn a lot from its first-ever international match against his country in Kolkata next month, though he admitted to the significant gap in the rankings between the two countries. India will face five-time World Cup champions Brazil in an international friendly at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata on October 3.

"We hope that Brazil and India can play a great game. It will bring many benefits to the Indian people and to the Indian national team, which will face a

team that is a five-time world champion," Cafu told reporters during his visit to the Pillai University here. "Well, if you go by the rankings, there is a significant difference between Brazil and India, but football has modernised."

Cafu also said India should benefit from FIFA's proposed plan to expand the number of participating teams to 64 from 2030 World Cup onwards from the 48 in 2026. FIFA is yet to take a final decision. The 56-year-old Cafu pointed at how smaller nations like Curacao and Cape Verde "played on equal terms" with bigger teams in the 2026 World Cup in USA, Mexico and Canada.